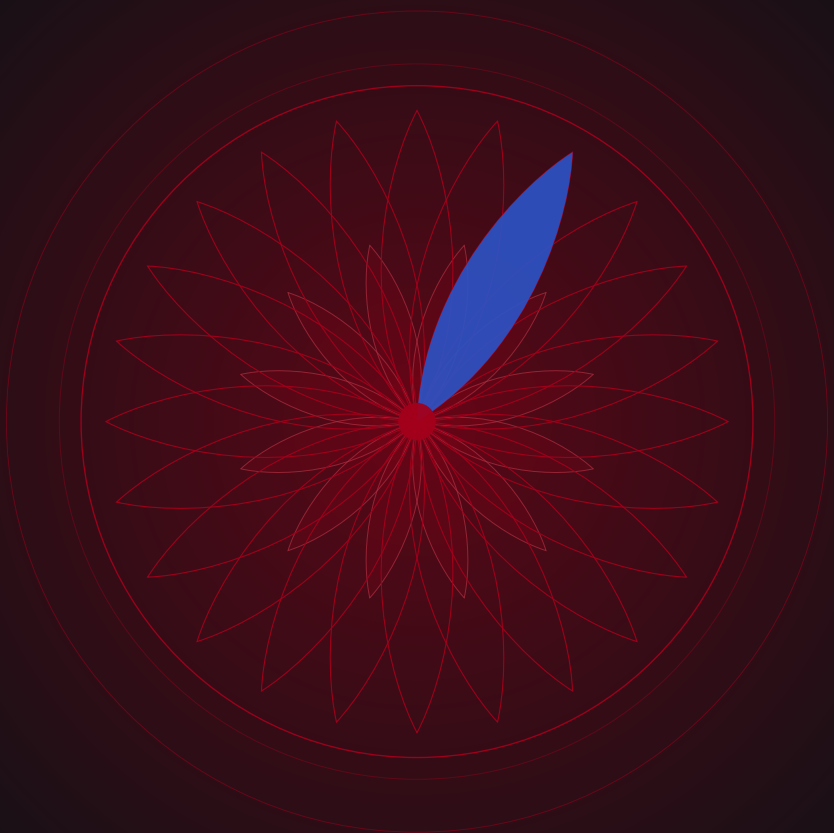


MATER SUSPIRIORUM

Matricide, Matrigenesis, and the Politics of Breath in Suspiria

ARGENTO / NICOLODI, 1977 • GUADAGNINO / KAJGANICH, 2018

Toward a Humanism of the Sigh

A DISSERTATION

OCTOBER 2026

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Matricide, Matrigenesis, and the Politics of Breath in *Suspiria* (Argento/Nicolodi, 1977; Guadagnino/Kajganich, 2018): Toward a Humanism of the Sigh.

A dissertation. October 2026.

Set in TeX Gyre Pagella, with Poppins and GFS Porson. Trim size 7 × 10 in.

ABSTRACT

This dissertation reads *Suspiria* as a single, internally divided work in two incarnations: the film written by Dario Argento and Daria Nicolodi and directed by Argento (1977), and the film written by David Kajganich and directed by Luca Guadagnino (2018). Against the critical habit that treats the first as an apolitical exercise in chromatic delirium and the second as a remake weighed down by history, it argues that the two films constitute a dialectical inquiry into the figure of the Mother as the concealed ground of European modernity's twin projects: humanist emancipation and its catastrophic negation. Reconstructing the genealogy of the Three Mothers from Thomas De Quincey's "Levana and Our Ladies of Sorrow" (1845) through the Marian *Mater Dolorosa*, J. J. Bachofen's *Mutterrecht*, Goethe's *Mütter* and Freud's "The Theme of the Three Caskets," and situating each film within its geopolitical palimpsest (the Upper Rhine of the *Malleus Maleficarum*, Erasmus, Bachofen, Steiner and Heidegger for the first; the Berlin of the *Deutscher Herbst*, of *Ausdruckstanz* and of post-Holocaust *Vergangenheitsbewältigung* for the second), the dissertation advances three theses.

First, the 1977 film stages emancipation as matricide. Under the double sign of the fairy tale and the lightning-flash of *Aufklärung*, its heroine renders visible and kills an invisible, respiring maternal sovereign, re-enacting both the founding murder of the mother that Luce Irigaray locates at the root of Western culture and the auto-da-fé of the early modern witch-hunt. Second, the 2018 film converts matricide into what is here termed *matrigenesis*: the daughter accedes to subjectivity not by killing the Mother but by becoming her, unseating a usurping, parasitic matriarchy whose economy of "borrowed" bodies is shown to be the genealogical double of völkisch maternalism, of women's *Mittäterschaft* under National Socialism, and of capital as Marx's vampiric "dead labour." Third, the hinge of both films is breath. In 1977 the Mother exists as an acousmatic wheeze that dies at the instant it is made visible; in 2018 breath becomes the medium of dance, of domination and of mercy.

Joining Marx's definition of religion as "the sigh of the oppressed creature" and "the opium of the people" (*das Opium des Volkes*), the Pauline Spirit that intercedes "with unutterable sighing" (*mit unaussprechlichem Seufzen*), and De Quincey's Lady of Sighs, visitant of "the Pariah, the Jew," the dissertation names the power that the 2018 film installs *suspirial sovereignty*: a sovereignty that neither decides on the exception (Schmitt), nor makes live (Foucault), nor makes die (Mbembe), but answers the sigh through three gifts: death to those who ask for it, testimony to those who mourn, and forgetting to those whose guilt is not their own. Susie Bannion's verdict to the analyst Josef Klemperer is read as the reassignment of Karl Jaspers's

"metaphysical guilt," whose jurisdiction Jaspers reserved to God alone, to a divine-feminine tribunal, a move that at once fulfils and stress-tests Irigaray's demand for "divine women."

Finally, against the authoritarian hazards of that sovereignty (the National Socialist euphemism of the *Gnadentod*, the conservative longing for a *Schlussstrich*, the perennial wish for a benevolent tyrant), the dissertation proposes a position that neither film fully occupies: a *humanism of the sigh*. Such a humanism is grounded not in the upright, self-fashioning subject that Pico della Mirandola proclaimed within months of the first printing of the *Malleus*, but in the breathing, inclined and indebted creature, and in *conspiration* (literally, breathing-together) as the minimal form of an ethical and political commons.

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She is the visitor of the Pariah, of the Jew, of the bondsman to the oar in the Mediterranean galleys.

— Thomas De Quincey, ``Levana and Our Ladies of Sorrow,'' *Suspiria de Profundis* (1845)

Religion is the sigh of the oppressed creature, the heart of a heartless world, as it is the spirit of spiritless conditions. It is the opium of the people.

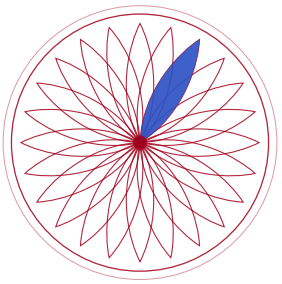
— Karl Marx, ``Contribution to the Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Right: Introduction'' (1844)

Divinity is what we need to become free, autonomous, sovereign.

— Luce Irigaray, ``Divine Women'' (1984)

atque in ventos vita recessit. (And life withdrew into the winds.)

— Virgil, *Aeneid* IV.705



MATER SUSPIRIORUM

Toward a Humanism of the Sigh

INTRODUCTION

De Profundis

The Sigh as a Philosophical Problem



SUSPIR

The word *suspiria* names a breath. Its root, *sub-spirare*, designates an exhalation drawn from below: a respiration that rises from beneath speech and stops short of it. Its theological horizon is the hundred-and-thirtieth Psalm, *De profundis clamavi ad te, Domine*, which Thomas De Quincey grafted onto the title of *Suspiria de Profundis* (1845) to designate a discourse of grief more primitive than lamentation. That two of the most consequential horror films of the European tradition bear this word as their title, and that neither ever explains it, is the problem from which this dissertation departs. A sigh is not a proposition. It is the minimal sign that a body suffers under conditions it cannot articulate, and for that reason it is the privileged sign of those whom Marx called oppressed creatures and De Quincey called "children of hereditary disgrace." Marx adds the decisive qualification: religious misery is at once the expression of real misery and a *Protestation* against it. The sigh, in other words, is already a protest that has not yet found its grammar. The hypothesis of what follows is that *Suspiria*, in both its incarnations, is a sustained meditation on this sign: on who sighs, on who hears, and on what kind of power arises when a sigh is answered.

1.1

Two Films, One Name: The Remake as Palimpsest

The reception of the 2018 film divided along an axis of fidelity. For one constituency it betrayed the delirious formalism of Argento's original; for another it rescued a "shallow" masterpiece by supplying the history it lacked. Both positions presuppose the remake as copy, judged by resemblance. Both filmmakers resisted the designation "remake," and Gérard Genette's typology of hypertextuality explains why they were right to do so: the later film is a hypertext that *transforms* rather than imitates its hypotext, displacing setting (Freiburg becomes divided Berlin), medium of movement (ballet becomes *Ausdruckstanz*), palette (Technicolor saturation becomes the browns and greys of a German winter), score (Goblin's progressive-rock assault becomes Thom Yorke's breathy elegy), and ontology (an invisible directress becomes a visible, decomposing body). Yet the most apposite model of the relation is contained in De Quincey's own volume. "The Palimpsest of the Human Brain," a section of *Suspiria de Profundis*, argues that the mind is a vellum on which "everlasting layers of ideas, images, feelings, have fallen upon your brain softly as light," each seeming to bury its predecessor, "and yet, in reality, not one has been extinguished." Freud's "Note upon the 'Mystic Writing-Pad' " (1925) secularises the same insight: the celluloid surface is wiped clean, while the wax beneath retains every trace.

The 2018 *Suspiria* is a palimpsest in this exact sense. Its surface erases the 1977 film; its depths retain it. The most legible trace is the casting of Jessica Harper, the 1977 heroine, as Anke Meier, the wife whom the psychoanalyst Josef Klemperer lost to the Nazi camps. The heroine of the first film returns in the second as a disappeared Jewish woman, which is to say as the figure that the first film could not see. The relation between the two works is therefore not one of copy and

original but of manifest and latent content. The later film is the earlier film's unconscious made conscious, and the analysis of that relation is the analysis of what the 1977 film repressed: history, the Holocaust, the Federal Republic's unfinished reckoning with its mothers. It is equally, and less commonly noticed, the analysis of what the 2018 film inherits without fully mastering: the fairy-tale grammar of matricide, the logic of the decapitable sovereign, and the iconography of the burning witch.

1.2

Four Authors and an Occluded Mother

The 1977 film is credited to Dario Argento and Daria Nicolodi as screenwriters. Auteurist criticism, from the *politique des auteurs* of the 1950s to the cult monographs of the 1990s, converted this collaboration into "Argento's *Suspiria*." The conversion is not innocent. Nicolodi, who repeatedly claimed a larger share of authorship than reception acknowledged, is the source of the film's founding anecdote: a grandmother who, she said, had gone as a very young woman to an academy in Germany to perfect her piano and discovered that black magic was taught there (some retellings place the school in Switzerland). Argento, for his part, spoke of a fascination with the "magic triangle" where France, Germany and Switzerland meet, the region in which Rudolf Steiner founded his anthroposophical community; Steiner's Goetheanum stands at Dornach, some seventy kilometres from Freiburg. Nicolodi is also the conduit through which De Quincey entered the project. Her erasure from the name of the work reproduces in the order of criticism the structure that the film dramatises in the order of fiction: a maternal source concealed behind a paternal signature.

The Three Mothers cycle completed this genealogy outside the frame. In *La terza madre* (2007), Nicolodi plays Elisa Mandy, the ghost of a white witch who died combating Mater Suspiriorum and who returns to protect her daughter Sarah, played by Asia Argento, Nicolodi's own daughter. A real mother plays a spectral mother guarding her real daughter against a mythic Mother. Few cinematic cycles inscribe a matrilineal transmission so literally into their production history, and few have been read so persistently through the name of the father. This dissertation therefore designates the films by their writing pairs (Argento/Nicolodi; Guadagnino/Kajganich) and treats collaborative authorship, including Tilda Swinton's tripled performance in 2018, as part of the works' meaning rather than as a matter of credits.

I.3

The Argument

The argument proceeds through three theses and one proposal.

The first thesis concerns the 1977 film, which stages emancipation as **matricide**. Suzy Bannion, an American innocent in a German fairy-tale forest, accedes to autonomy by locating, illuminating and stabbing a hidden maternal sovereign, Helena Markos, after which the academy burns. The structure is the one Erich Neumann codified as the hero's "dragon fight" against the Terrible Mother, the one Mozart and Schikaneder staged as the overthrow of the Queen of the Night, and the one Irigaray identified as the buried foundation of Western culture: the murder of the mother. The film performs it under the lightning-flash of *Aufklärung*, so that enlightenment and witch-burning coincide in a single image, exactly as Horkheimer and Adorno predicted when they wrote that enlightenment reverts to mythology.

The second thesis concerns the 2018 film, which converts matricide into **matrigenesis**. Susie Bannion does not kill the Mother; she becomes her, or reveals that she always was. What she destroys is a usurper: Markos, a decaying body that claims the title of Mater Suspiriorum and sustains itself by "borrowing" the bodies of young women. This usurping matriarchy is shown to be continuous with the völkisch maternalism of the Third Reich and with the complicity (*Mittäterschaft*) of ordinary women within it; economically, it is a creditor regime that converts bodies into collateral and guilt into debt, a structure the dissertation calls the **creditor matriarchy**.

The third thesis concerns breath. In 1977 the Mother is present only as respiration: a whistling snore that the students track through the dormitory and a wheeze that Suzy hears in the dark before lightning makes its source visible. In Michel Chion's terms, Markos is an *acousmêtre*, an unseen voice endowed with ubiquity and omnipotence, who loses her power at the moment of deacousmatisation. In 2018, breath becomes the substance of dance, of the witches' power and, finally, of mercy. The title of both films is thus not ornamental but structural: *Suspiria* is a theory of the sigh.

From these theses the dissertation derives its central concept. **Suspirial sovereignty** names the power that the 2018 film installs at its climax: a sovereignty whose proper object is breath, and whose mode is not decision but answer. It is defined by three gifts (death to those who ask for it, testimony to those who mourn, forgetting to those whose guilt is not their own) and by one violence (the annihilation of the usurpers). The concept is reconstructed through Marx's "sigh of the oppressed creature," through the Pauline Spirit that sighs on behalf of a creation in labour, through De Quincey's Lady of Sighs, and through Virgil's Juno, who sends Iris to release Dido's struggling breath into the winds.

The proposal follows from a critique of that sovereignty. Because a goddess who dispenses death and forgetting is also the image of a benevolent tyrant, and

because "mercy death" (*Gnadentod*) was the euphemism under which the National Socialist state murdered the disabled, the 2018 film's resolution cannot be accepted without remainder. The dissertation therefore proposes a third position, a **humanism of the sigh**, which retains the 2018 film's attention to breath, consent and testimony while relinquishing sovereignty as such, and which finds its political form in **conspiration**, the etymological core of "conspiracy": breathing together.

1.4

Method: Constellation, Pathos Formula, Controlled Overinterpretation

Three methodological commitments govern the inquiry. The first is constellational. Walter Benjamin's prologue to the *Trauerspiel* book holds that ideas relate to phenomena as constellations relate to stars: an idea is not deduced from its objects but becomes legible in their configuration. Adorno's inaugural lecture of 1931 converted this into a programme of interpretation by arrangement. The dissertation accordingly assembles constellations (the year 1486, the years 1844–1845, the year 1977) whose elements illuminate one another without being reducible to causal influence.

The second commitment is iconological in Aby Warburg's sense. Warburg's *Pathosformel*, the gestural formula of intense emotion that survives (*nachlebt*) from antiquity into later art, provides the means of reading the bodies of both films: the maenad's thrown-back head in the convulsions of *Ausdruckstanz*, the hysteric's arc in the contortions of the mirror room, the *Mater Dolorosa*'s pierced breast in Susie's opened chest. Warburg's 1923 lecture on the serpent ritual, which traces the lightning-snake of myth to the captured electricity of modernity, will prove unexpectedly exact for a film in which a coven is likened to a serpent and its head is found by lightning.

The third commitment is hermeneutic. Following Gadamer's argument that a work's meaning exceeds its author's intention, Ricoeur's "surplus of meaning," and Umberto Eco's distinction between the *intentio auctoris* and the *intentio operis*, the dissertation practises what may be called controlled overinterpretation. Several of its readings (that the façade of the 1977 academy reproduces the Freiburg house in which Erasmus lived; that a blind man killed by his guide dog on Munich's Königsplatz figures a people destroyed by its *Führer*; that the epilogue of the 2018 film, a sliced pear in a divided city, figures a bisected womb) make no claim about what the filmmakers intended. They claim that the works, placed in their historical constellation, sustain these meanings and are illuminated by them. Each such reading is flagged as such.

I.5

Plan of the Dissertation

Chapter One reconstructs the genealogy of the Three Mothers: De Quincey's Levana and her sisters; the Marian matrix of the *Stabat Mater*; the triplicity of Fates, Matronae and Freud's three caskets; Bachofen's *Mutterrecht* and its double afterlife in emancipatory and völkisch thought; Goethe's Mothers and the phantom Helena; the constellation of 1844–1845; and the Pauline theology of the unutterable sigh. **Chapter Two** reads the 1977 film as a fairy tale of matricidal enlightenment set in an Upper Rhine palimpsest, attending to its chromatic metaphysics, its acoustic regime, its emblems of Hera (iris and peacock) and its feminist ambivalence. **Chapter Three** turns to dance: the lineage of *Ausdruckstanz* from Hellerau and Monte Verità to Mary Wigman's *Hexentanz*, its entanglement with nationalism, its kinship with hysteria and possession, and its post-Auschwitz transformation in Madame Blanc's pedagogy. **Chapter Four** reads the 2018 film as a *Mütterfilm* of the German Autumn, concerned with guilt, debt, complicity and the crypt. **Chapter Five** is devoted to Josef Klemperer as the last humanist. **Chapter Six** sets both films within a comparative constellation of feminist and humanist works. **Chapter Seven** develops the theory of matrigenesis and suspirial sovereignty. The **Conclusion** argues for a humanism of the sigh.

CHAPTER ONE



Our Ladies of Sorrow

A Genealogy of the Three Mothers

MATRE

The Three Mothers are not an invention of Italian horror cinema. They are the late, demonised form of a figure that runs through Roman domestic religion, Marian devotion, Germanic votive cult, Romantic prose, Victorian anthropology, Freudian metapsychology and German philosophy of history. This chapter reconstructs that genealogy in order to establish one claim on which the rest of the dissertation depends: every strand of it converges on breath, and specifically on the sigh as the sign of a suffering that is at once maternal and oppressed.

1.1

Levana and the Pedagogy of Grief

Suspiria de Profundis appeared in *Blackwood's Edinburgh Magazine* in 1845, announced as a sequel to the *Confessions of an English Opium-Eater* (1821), and it remained a constellation of fragments: "The Palimpsest of the Human Brain," "Levana and Our Ladies of Sorrow," "The Apparition of the Brocken," "Savannah-la-Mar." Its governing deity is Levana, a minor Roman goddess whom Augustine lists among the divinities of childhood as the one who lifts the infant from the earth. The rite she presided over was juridical before it was sentimental. The newborn was laid on the ground; the father's act of raising it (*tollere liberum*) signified acknowledgement and admission to the household, and his refusal signified exposure. Levana therefore names the hinge at which the *patria potestas*, the Roman father's *vitae necisque potestas* or power of life and death, decided whether a life would be raised or abandoned.

De Quincey performs a double transformation on this material. He feminises the sovereign act, assigning to a goddess the gesture that Roman law reserved to the father, and he converts its object from admission into education. Levana, in his allegory, does not educate by grammar or precept but by grief, and her ministers are three sisters, the Ladies of Sorrow, who do not speak. Their communication is a mute, emblematic language that the dreamer can only translate. The eldest, Mater Lachrymarum, "Our Lady of Tears," is the mother who raves for vanished faces; De Quincey places her in Rama, with Rachel weeping for her children, so that the massacre of the innocents becomes her primal scene. The youngest, Mater Tenebrarum, "Our Lady of Darkness," is "the defier of God," "the mother of lunacies, and the suggestress of suicides."

The second sister is the one who concerns us. Mater Suspiriorum, "Our Lady of Sighs," never scales the clouds and wears no diadem; her head droops and fastens on the dust; she weeps not and groans not, but sighs inaudibly at intervals; she is "humble to abjectness." Above all, she is defined by those she visits. She is "the visitor of the Pariah, of the Jew, of the bondsman to the oar in the Mediterranean galleys; of the English criminal in Norfolk Island, blotted out from the books of remembrance in sweet far-off England." Every woman sitting in darkness, whose heaven-born instincts have been stifled by social necessities; every nun defrauded of her unreturning May-time; every captive in every dungeon; all that are betrayed

and all that are rejected; "outcasts by traditionary law, and children of hereditary disgrace": all these, De Quincey writes, walk with Our Lady of Sighs.

Three features of this portrait will govern the reading of both films. First, the Lady of Sighs is in her source not a demon but a patroness of the abject. Her retinue is a precise census of the excluded of mid-nineteenth-century Europe: the racialised outcast, the Jew, the galley slave, the transported convict, the woman whose desires society has stifled, the nun confined by her kin. Before she was a witch, the Mother of Sighs was a figure of solidarity with the oppressed, and the phrase "humble to abjectness" anticipates by more than a century the category Julia Kristeva would make central to feminist theories of horror. Second, her sign is the inaudible sigh: not the scream of the third sister nor the tears of the first, but a breath that does not reach speech. Third, her retinue is defined by erasure ("blotted out from the books of remembrance") and by inheritance ("children of hereditary disgrace"). Memory and hereditary guilt are thus inscribed in the figure's origin, a full century and a quarter before the 2018 film sets her among the second generation of a nation whose guilt was hereditary in the most literal sense.

Argento's cycle inverts this figure. In *Inferno* (1980) the alchemist-architect Varelli's treatise describes three malign sisters, for whom he built houses in Freiburg, Rome and New York, and who govern the world through sorrow, tears and darkness. De Quincey's patronesses of the abject become its persecutors. The 2018 film, it will be argued, partially reverses the inversion: its Mother of Sighs returns, as De Quincey's did, to visit the Jew and to restore to remembrance a woman blotted out of it.

1.2

The Marian Matrix: Stabat Mater and the Pierced Breast

"Our Ladies of Sorrow" is a plural parody of "Our Lady of Sorrows," the *Mater Dolorosa* of Catholic devotion. Her cult is organised around the Seven Sorrows, inaugurated by Simeon's prophecy in Luke 2:35 ("Yea, a sword shall pierce through thy own soul also") and culminating at the foot of the cross. Its iconography is precise: the Virgin's breast pierced by one sword or by seven. Its liturgical form is the thirteenth-century sequence *Stabat Mater dolorosa*, traditionally attributed to Jacopone da Todi and set most famously by Pergolesi in 1736. De Quincey, a Protestant, triplicates this Mother and darkens her. Argento and Nicolodi, Catholic Italians, re-Catholicise her: the Mother of Tears dwells in Rome, and the cycle's final film is a war over the relics of the Church.

Kristeva's essay "Stabat Mater," first published in *Tel Quel* in 1977 under the title "Héréthique de l'amour," is the indispensable theoretical companion to this matrix. Written in two columns, one theorising the cult of the Virgin and the other recording the author's own experience of childbirth, it argues that the Marian cult was the West's means of managing maternity: removing the mother from sexuality and death, granting her the ear and the breast and the tears while withholding

the voice. Marina Warner's *Alone of All Her Sex* (1976) had shown the same exclusion historically. The *Mater Dolorosa* is permitted to weep and to sigh; she is not permitted to decide. This is the Marian prohibition that the 2018 film transgresses when its Mother of Sighs opens her own breast, a gesture whose iconographic ancestor is the pierced heart of Our Lady of Sorrows and whose meaning, as Chapter Seven argues, is the conversion of the wound into an organ of breath and birth.

1.3

Triplicity: Fates, Matronae and the Three Caskets

The triplicity of the Mothers belongs to the oldest stratum of European religion. The Greek Moirai spin, measure and cut the thread of life; the Roman Parcae inherit their office. The Norse Norns are named Urðr, Verðandi and Skuld, and the third name, cognate with the German *Schuld*, joins futurity to debt and guilt in a single word, an etymology to which Chapter Four will return. Hecate *triformis* stands at the crossroads. Most pertinently for a film set on the Rhine, the votive altars of the Roman Rhineland preserve the cult of the Matronae, triple mother goddesses carved as three seated women, two of them in great bonnets. The Three Mothers are autochthonous to the region in which Argento placed the first of them.

Freud's "The Theme of the Three Caskets" (1913) gives this triplicity its modern theory. Beginning from Bassanio's choice of the leaden casket in *The Merchant of Venice* and from Lear's three daughters, Freud notes that the third woman is always the silent one, and that dumbness in dreams represents death. The three sisters are the Fates, and the third is the Goddess of Death. His conclusion reads the triad as the three forms the mother takes in a man's life: the mother who bears him, the beloved chosen after her pattern, and Mother Earth, who receives him again. Freud adds that the myth reverses necessity into choice: the man appears to *choose* the woman who is in fact his death. De Quincey's mute sisters and Freud's silent goddess thus coincide, and the 2018 film literalises their identification when a single performer, Małgosia Bela, incarnates both Susie's dying mother and the figure of Death.

The twentieth century multiplied the triad. Robert Graves's *The White Goddess* (1948) systematised it as maiden, mother and crone and supplied Gerald Gardner's Wicca (*Witchcraft Today*, 1954) with its theology. Erich Neumann's Jungian studies, *The Origins and History of Consciousness* (1949) and *The Great Mother* (1955), split the archetype into a Good and a Terrible Mother and narrated the birth of the ego as the hero's "dragon fight" against the latter. Neumann's schema is, almost scene for scene, the plot of the 1977 *Suspiria*: an ego that individuates by descending into the maternal labyrinth, finding the devouring Mother in the dark and slaying her. Its masculinism is constitutive. Consciousness is born from the death of the Mother, and the daughter, when she is the hero, must become a son to be born at all.

1.4

Mutterrecht and Its Double Afterlife

In 1861 the Basel jurist Johann Jakob Bachofen published *Das Mutterrecht*, positing that human societies passed from promiscuous hetaerism through a chthonic, Demetrian gynocracy before being overcome by Apollonian paternity. His key witness was Aeschylus. In the *Eumenides*, Apollo argues that the mother is not the parent of the child but only the nurse of the sown seed; Athena, born motherless from the head of Zeus, casts the deciding vote to acquit the matricide Orestes; and the Erinyes, the archaic avengers of maternal blood, are domesticated into the "Kindly Ones." For Bachofen the *Oresteia* recorded, in juridical form, the world-historical passage from mother-right to father-right. Law itself was founded on an acquitted matricide.

Bachofen's thesis had a double afterlife, and the duplicity is decisive for the 2018 film. In one line it became emancipatory: Engels's *Origin of the Family, Private Property and the State* (1884) named the overthrow of mother-right "the world-historical defeat of the female sex"; Erich Fromm's essay on mother-right (1934) made it a resource for critical social psychology; Marija Gimbutas's *The Gods and Goddesses of Old Europe* (1974) and the German matriarchy-research of Heide Göttner-Abendroth (*Die Göttin und ihr Heros*, 1980) made it a charter for 1970s feminism. In another line it became völkisch. Around 1900 the Munich "Cosmic Circle" of Ludwig Klages and Alfred Schuler read Bachofen's chthonic mothers as a blood-bound, pre-rational life opposed to the abstractions of spirit, the programme Klages would later systematise as *Der Geist als Widersacher der Seele* (1929–1932). In 1926 the selection *Der Mythus von Orient und Occident* reissued Bachofen with a long introduction by Alfred Baeumler, soon to become one of National Socialism's philosophers of education. At Ascona, the psychoanalyst Otto Gross preached matriarchal revolution against the patriarchal state until his father, the criminologist Hans Gross, had him committed in 1913.

The Mother in German thought is therefore bivalent. She can sponsor the critique of property and patriarchy, or she can sponsor the community of blood and soil. The 2018 *Suspiria* is built on this bivalence. Its coven is split between Madame Blanc and Helena Markos; its central work is a dance called *Volk*; its matriarchy is simultaneously a refuge for women within a male state and a body that consumes its daughters. To read it through Bachofen's emancipatory heirs alone is to miss its argument; to read it through the völkisch heirs alone is to miss its hope.

1.5

Goethe's Mothers and the Phantom Helena

In the first act of *Faust II* (1832), Mephistopheles speaks of goddesses enthroned in solitude, around whom there is no place and still less time, and Faust shudders at their name: *Die Mütter! Mütter! — 's klingt so wunderlich!* The Mothers preside over *Gestaltung, Umgestaltung, / Des ewigen Sinnes ewige Unterhaltung*

(formation, transformation, the eternal mind's eternal re-creation). They are the matrix of forms, and Faust descends to them with a key in order to bring back the phantom of Helen. The same drama contains, in *Faust I*, the Walpurgis Night on the Brocken, where old Baubo rides in alone on a sow, and it ends with the *Chorus Mysticus*: *Das Ewig-Weibliche / Zieht uns hinan*, the Eternal-Feminine draws us upward. De Quincey's *Suspiria* includes "The Apparition of the Brocken": the witches' mountain is already inside the text from which both films take their name.

Goethe's conjunction of Mothers and Helen yields a reading of Helena Markos that is offered here as hermeneutic surplus rather than as authorial intention. Markos is Greek, and her given name is Helen's. The oldest revisionist tradition of the Helen myth, Stesichorus's *Palinode* and Euripides' *Helen* (412 BCE), holds that the woman at Troy was an *eidolon*, a phantom fashioned by the gods, while the true Helen waited elsewhere. The 2018 film's revelation has exactly this structure: the Markos who claims to be Mater Suspiriorum is a phantom of the Mother, while the true Mother has been elsewhere all along, in Ohio, in the body of a Mennonite girl. The Faustian scheme in which the Eternal-Feminine is the redemptive *object* of masculine striving is the scheme the 2018 film overturns: its feminine is not drawn upward by anyone, and it draws upward no one but itself.

1.6

The Constellation of 1844–1845

In 1844, in the single issue of the *Deutsch-Französische Jahrbücher*, Marx wrote: *Die Religion ist der Seufzer der bedrängten Kreatur, das Gemüt einer herzlosen Welt, wie sie der Geist geistloser Zustände ist. Sie ist das Opium des Volkes.* The sentence condenses, with uncanny economy, the three nouns around which the two *Suspiria*s turn. The sigh (*Seufzer*) is the film's title. Opium is the drug of De Quincey's *Confessions*, of which *Suspiria de Profundis* is the sequel, and drugged wine is the instrument of the 1977 coven's control. The *Volk* is the name of the 2018 company's signature dance. Marx continues that criticism has plucked the imaginary flowers from the chain, not so that humanity should bear the chain without fantasy or consolation, but so that it should cast off the chain and pluck the living flower. Chapter Two will argue that the 1977 film stages this sentence literally: its secret door is opened by turning a painted iris, an imaginary flower behind which lies the chain.

In the same Parisian months Marx befriended Heinrich Heine, whose *Deutschland. Ein Wintermärchen* appeared in 1844: a winter's tale of Germany, its title a description of the 2018 film's season and palette. Heine had earlier, in "Elementargeister" (1837), transmitted the Slavic legend of the Wilis, brides who die before their wedding and rise at night to dance to death any man they meet; Théophile Gautier made it the libretto of *Giselle* (1841), the founding ballet of dead women dancing. In 1845 Hans Christian Andersen published "The Red Shoes," in which a girl condemned to dance without rest has her feet struck off by the executioner, and in the same year De Quincey published *Suspiria de Profundis*. The

years 1844–1845 thus assemble the four elements the 2018 film will recombine in Berlin's winter of 1977: the sigh of the oppressed creature, the German winter, the dance of damned or dead girls, and the Lady of Sighs. Call this the *suspirial constellation*.

1.7

Pneuma and Kreatur: The Theology of the Unutterable Sigh

Marx's vocabulary is not his own. *Kreatur* and *Seufzer* are Luther's, and they come from the eighth chapter of Paul's Epistle to the Romans. In 8:22 the whole creation "groaneth and travaileth in pain together until now" (συστενάζει καὶ συνωδίνει), which Luther renders *alle Kreatur sehnt sich mit uns und ängstet sich noch immerdar*. In 8:26 the Spirit itself intercedes for us στεναγμοῖς ἀλαλήτοις, *mit unaussprechlichem Seufzen*, with unutterable sighing. Two consequences follow. First, the Pauline groan is maternal: συνωδίνει names the pangs of childbirth, so that the sighing of creation is the labour of a world being born. Second, the one who sighs on behalf of the creature is the πνεῦμα, a word that means breath before it means spirit. When Marx calls religion the sigh of the oppressed creature, he secularises a theology in which breath, birth-labour and intercession for the oppressed are a single act.

The Mother of Sighs is the feminine figure of this act. Beneath the Gothic apparatus of both films lies a theological grammar in which a maternal Spirit sighs on behalf of a creation in labour, and in which the sigh is at once the sign of oppression, the labour of birth and the medium of intercession. Eric Santner has named "creaturely life" the condition of exposure to sovereign power that Benjamin discerned in the baroque *Trauerspiel*, where even the sovereign is a creature; Luce Irigaray, in *The Forgetting of Air* (1983), has argued that Western metaphysics forgot the element of breath and with it the maternal-feminine that sustains every speaking being. The genealogy reconstructed in this chapter converges on both diagnoses. The Three Mothers, stripped of their Gothic finery, are the forgotten air of European thought: the breath of the creature that sighs, labours and, in sighing, protests. The question both films pose is what becomes of that breath when it acquires a body, a house and a power of its own.



CHAPTER TWO

Behind the Façade of Humanism

Argento, Nicolodi and the Matricidal Enlightenment (1977)

IRIS

The 1977 *Suspiria* has been praised for its colour and dismissed for its sense with such regularity that the two verdicts have hardened into one: a film of pure surface, its plot a pretext, its world a stage. This chapter argues that the verdict mistakes the medium of the film's argument for the absence of one. The film thinks in colour, sound and architecture, and what it thinks is a fable of enlightenment in which the subject is born by finding, illuminating and killing a hidden Mother. Its surfaces are not empty but stratified. The façade of its academy belongs to a humanist; its locations lie on the ground of the witch-hunt, of the critique of humanism and of National Socialism; its founding date is the year in which modernity acquired its apparatus for seeing the invisible; its key is a flower that condenses Romantic longing and the critique of religion; and its ending is an auto-da-fé. The film narrates none of this. It inscribes it, as a palimpsest inscribes what its surface erases.

2.1 THE WHALE HOUSE: ERASMUS, THE *MALLEUS* AND THE CONSTELLATION OF 1486

The Tanz Akademie's crimson exterior reproduces the Haus zum Walfisch on Freiburg's Franziskanerstraße, a late-Gothic house built in the 1510s for Jakob Villinger, treasurer to the Emperor Maximilian I, and rebuilt after the raid of November 1944 that devastated the old town. Argento's production designer, Giuseppe Bassan, rebuilt its façade again on a stage in Rome. The academy is therefore a studio replica of a postwar reconstruction: a façade twice removed from its original. That original had a famous tenant. In 1529, when iconoclasm overran Basel, Desiderius Erasmus withdrew to Catholic Freiburg and lived in the Walfisch until 1531. The house of the witches wears the face of the house of the prince of humanists.

The juxtaposition condenses the central quarrel of early modern anthropology. In *De libero arbitrio* (1524) Erasmus defended the freedom of the will; in *De servo arbitrio* (1525) Luther answered that the human will is a beast of burden (*iumentum*) that goes wherever its rider directs and cannot choose whether God or Satan rides it. Luther's figure is already a theory of possession. The academy rehearses the quarrel in architectural form: an Erasmian façade of free self-determination encloses a Lutheran interior of ridden wills, whose students are drugged, hexed and steered. Erasmus's masterpiece adds a further irony. *Moriae Encomium* (1511) is spoken by a goddess, Folly, who praises herself and mocks the theologians and monks who would furnish the witch-hunt with its doctrine. The classic text of Northern humanism is the monologue of a female deity. Behind the façade of humanism, a goddess was speaking all along.

The region's other monuments sharpen the irony. In 1486 or early 1487, at Speyer on the Rhine, the Dominican inquisitor Heinrich Kramer (Institoris), a native of Sélestat in Alsace, published the *Malleus Maleficarum*, prefaced by Innocent VIII's bull *Summis desiderantes affectibus* (1484), which had named the ecclesiastical provinces of Upper Germany and the Rhineland as infested by witches.

The *Malleus* derives all witchcraft from a carnal appetite it declares insatiable in women, etymologises *femina* as *fe minus*, "less faith," and reserves a particular chapter for midwives, accused of killing infants in the womb or offering the newborn to devils. Its target is not only woman but reproduction: the hands that deliver children. In the same year in Rome, Giovanni Pico della Mirandola composed the *Oratio* intended to open the public disputation of his nine hundred theses. In it God tells Adam that he has been given no fixed seat, form or function, so that, as the free and sovereign shaper of himself, he may fashion himself in whatever form he prefers, sinking toward the brutes or being reborn toward the divine. Innocent VIII suspended the disputation and in 1487 condemned the theses. Within a single pontificate the Church licensed the inquisitors of witches and silenced the philosopher of human self-fashioning. The year 1486 gives birth to modern humanism and to the systematic persecution of women as one event seen from two sides, and it bequeaths to both *Suspiria*s their deepest problem: the humanist subject is defined by the capacity to give itself form, the witch by the loss of that capacity to another.

Four centuries later the same Upper Rhine produced a second constellation. In Basel, Jacob Burckhardt published *Die Kultur der Renaissance in Italien* (1860), whose second part, "The Development of the Individual," installed the self-fashioning Renaissance subject as the origin of modernity; a year later his colleague Bachofen published *Das Mutterrecht* (1861); a decade after that their younger colleague Nietzsche published *The Birth of Tragedy* (1872), restoring to the Greek origin the ecstatic dances of Dionysus's maenads. In one city, within a dozen years, the humanist individual, the archaic Mothers and the dancing maenads were theorised side by side. Just south of Basel, at Dornach, Steiner would later raise the Goetheanum, whose eurythmy proposed dance as visible speech. Freiburg's university completes the figure. There Edmund Husserl taught from 1916; there Edith Stein, his assistant, received her doctorate in 1916 for *Zum Problem der Einfühlung*, the founding phenomenology of empathy, before being denied the habilitation then closed to women and, in August 1942, deported by the SS from the Netherlands and murdered in the gas chambers of Auschwitz-Birkenau; there Martin Heidegger, who joined the NSDAP in May 1933 and remained a member until 1945, delivered his Rectoral Address as the university's National Socialist rector and, in 1946, wrote the *Letter on Humanism*, which declared the humanisms of the metaphysical tradition incapable of thinking the essence of the human and named language "the house of Being." Freiburg is the capital of the twentieth-century critique of humanism, and on 22 October 1940, in an operation ordered by the Gauleiters Robert Wagner and Josef Bürckel, its Jewish citizens were among some 6,500 Jews deported from Baden and the Saar-Palatinate to the camp at Gurs in southern France, from which many were later deported to Auschwitz and murdered. None of this appears in the 1977 film. All of it lies in the ground on which its house is drawn.

Munich, where most of the film's exteriors were shot between July and November 1976, adds the stratum the film most visibly suppresses. Daniel, the

blind pianist dismissed from the academy after his dog bites Madame Blanc's nephew, is seen in the Hofbräuhaus, the beer hall in which Hitler proclaimed the twenty-five-point programme of the NSDAP on 24 February 1920, and dies on the Königsplatz, the neoclassical square that the regime paved with granite as a parade ground for its rallies and whose slabs were removed only in the late 1980s. Suzy learns of witchcraft from the psychiatrist Frank Mandel in the shadow of the BMW tower beside the Olympic Park, where in September 1972 the Palestinian organisation Black September took members of the Israeli team hostage and murdered eleven of them, in the Olympic Village and during a failed rescue at Fürstenfeldbruck, where a West German police officer was also killed; she and Sara swim and talk in the Müller'sches Volksbad, the "people's bath." And the city, Argento later recalled, was hung with black on the crew's arrival: Cardinal Julius Döpfner had died in July 1976, and in 1977 his see passed to Joseph Ratzinger, who in 1981 would become Prefect of the Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith, the institutional heir of the Roman Inquisition.

Daniel's death warrants the controlled overinterpretation announced in the Introduction. In German a guide dog is a *Blindenführhund*, literally a leader (*Führer*) for the blind. A blind man, led into the square where the regime had assembled its people in ranks, is killed by the creature that leads him, after it has turned toward something in the empty air that he cannot see. The film proposes no allegory; its location supplies one, the fate of a people that followed its *Führer* blindly onto the Königsplatz. The 1977 *Suspiria* is not a historical film. It is a film shot inside history's sediment, and that sediment is what the 2018 film will excavate.

2.2

Once upon a Time: The Split Mother

Argento conceived the film as a fairy tale and, by his own account, intended its pupils to be young girls; when the producers refused, he had the door handles set at the height of the actresses' heads, so that grown women would reach upward like children. The palette was modelled on Disney's *Snow White and the Seven Dwarfs* (1937), and the film was printed by Technicolor's dye-transfer process, then all but extinct. These are not anecdotes of style. They place the film inside the genre whose psychoanalytic function Bruno Bettelheim had theorised in *The Uses of Enchantment* (1976), published the year before: the fairy tale, he argued, splits the mother into a good mother who is dead and a wicked stepmother who can be hated and destroyed, so that the child may work through ambivalence without guilt.

The Grimms' editorial history shows that the split is a work of censorship. In the first edition of the *Kinder- und Hausmärchen* (1812), the queen who orders Snow White's heart cut out is her mother; she becomes a stepmother only in the second edition of 1819. In the first version of "Hänsel und Gretel" it is the children's mother who proposes to abandon them in the forest; later editions make her, too, a stepmother. The bourgeois family required that the murderous mother

be a stranger. The 1977 film undoes the censorship without restoring the mother. Its heroine has no visible family; the only mothers in her world are the deputy directress, Madame Blanc, who administers, and the hidden directress, Helena Markos, who sustains. There is no good mother whose loss must be mourned, only a monstrous one to be found and killed. Its plot condenses the two Grimm tales: the poisoned apple returns as the drugged food and wine that hold Suzy in stupor, Snow White's glass coffin as the dormitory in which the pupils sleep beneath the Mother's snoring shadow, and Gretel's oven, into which a girl pushes a witch, as the fire that consumes the academy at the end. Bettelheim, who had survived Dachau and Buchenwald and who popularised the theory of the "refrigerator mother" whose coldness causes her child's autism, embodies the twentieth century's alliance of psychoanalysis and mother-blame. After his death in 1990, former residents of the Orthogenic School he directed in Chicago accused him of hitting and humiliating the children in his care, accounts gathered in Richard Pollak's biography *The Creation of Dr. B* (1997), and the folklorist Alan Dundes (1991) showed that *The Uses of Enchantment* borrowed without acknowledgement from Julius Heuscher's *A Psychiatric Study of Fairy Tales* (1963). The 1977 film belongs to that alliance. Its plot is the hero-myth that Neumann called the dragon fight, with a girl in the hero's place.

2.3

A House Founded in 1895

Frank Mandel tells Suzy that the academy was founded in 1895 by Helena Markos, a Greek émigrée reputed to be a witch. The date is never explained. It condenses the most extraordinary year in the history of visibility. On 28 December 1895 the Lumière brothers held the first paid public screening of the Cinématographe in Paris; their first film shows workers, most of them women, streaming out of the factory gates at Lyon, a city through which, Argento said, the journey that inspired *Suspiria* had passed. In the same year Breuer and Freud published *Studies on Hysteria*, which made the symptomatic female body legible as a text; on the night of 23–24 July Freud dreamed of Irma's injection, the specimen dream of psychoanalysis, in which he looks into a woman's open throat, a sight Lacan would read as the encounter with formless flesh beyond every image; on 8 November Wilhelm Röntgen discovered the rays that made the inside of the body visible, and on 22 December he imaged the hand of his wife, Anna Bertha, who is reported to have said that she had seen her own death; and Gustave Le Bon published *Psychologie des foules*, which made visible the irrational soul of the mass that the twentieth century's leaders would learn to command.

Cinema, hysteria, radiography, the crowd: four technologies of exposing what was hidden, born in the year Markos founded her house. The academy is their occult twin, a dark room in which a body that cannot be seen sustains an institution, and the film is the instrument that finally exposes her. The 1977 *Suspiria* is a film about cinema as an apparatus of exposure, and its climax is the dream of

Irma's injection carried through: the heroine finds the hidden woman, makes her visible and drives a blade into her throat.

The throat is not incidental. The film's murders cluster at the organs of breath and voice. Pat Hingle, the student who flees on the first night, is stabbed through the heart (the camera shows the blade entering the beating organ, an anatomised parody of the *Mater Dolorosa*'s pierced breast) and hanged through a stained-glass ceiling by a cord around her neck. Sara's throat is cut with a razor; Daniel's is torn out by his own dog; Markos dies of a wound in the neck. The film kills at the throat because its antagonist is a breath.

2.4

The Deeds and Sufferings of Light

Argento and his cinematographer Luciano Tovoli lit the academy through coloured gels and printed the result in dye-transfer Technicolor, producing reds, blues and greens of a saturation that seem less to fall on surfaces than to bleed from them. Criticism has tended to describe this palette in Newtonian terms, as the decomposition of white light into its spectral components, and to treat it as an addition to the narrative. Its proper theory is Goethean. In the preface to *Zur Farbenlehre* (1810), Goethe defined colours as "deeds of light, deeds and sufferings" (*Taten des Lichts, Taten und Leiden*), and against Newton he derived them not from the analysis of light but from its encounter with darkness through a turbid medium (*das Trübe*). In the part of the work devoted to the "sensory-moral effect" of colour, he described blue as producing on the eye a peculiar and "almost inexpressible" (*fast unaussprechliche*) effect, "a charming nothing" (*ein reizendes Nichts*) that does not press toward us but draws us after it, as we follow an agreeable object that flees.

The 1977 film's colours are in this precise sense the sufferings of light: affects rather than signs, passions undergone by the visible itself. They do not symbolise danger; they suffer it. And Goethe's blue anticipates the film's central device almost to the letter. The blue that recedes and draws the subject after it is the blue iris that will draw Suzy into the Mother's chamber, and its effect is "almost unutterable," the adjective Luther gave to the Spirit's sighing in Romans 8. The palette is also Munich's. In 1911, in the city where the film's exteriors were shot, Kandinsky and Marc founded *Der Blaue Reiter*, and Kandinsky's *On the Spiritual in Art*, steeped in the theosophy of Blavatsky and Steiner, assigned to blue a heavenly depth that calls the human toward the infinite. In 1937 the regime exhibited Kandinsky's work in Munich as "degenerate art." The film's colour is the return of an occult chromatics that German modernism had theorised and German fascism had expelled. The 2018 film, by contrast, filters its Berlin through browns and greys, as though its light passed through Goethe's turbid medium; there, the medium is history.

2.5

The Blue Iris: Four Readings of a Flower

On the first night, fleeing the academy into the storm, Pat Hingle cries out words that the wind tears apart; Suzy catches only fragments, among them "secret" and "iris." At the climax she understands. The walls of Madame Blanc's office are painted with irises, and turning the blue one opens a hidden door to the coven's chamber and the Mother's bed. The flower admits at least four readings, which the film superimposes.

The first is Romantic. In Novalis's *Heinrich von Ofterdingen* (1802), the blue flower the young poet sees in a dream, a face trembling within its petals, becomes the emblem of infinite longing (*Sehnsucht*), and Heinrich's journey toward it begins as a journey with his mother to her native city. The blue flower leads back to the Mother. The second is Marxian. In 1844 Marx wrote that criticism has plucked the imaginary flowers from the chain, not so that humanity should wear the chain without fantasy or consolation, but so that it should throw off the chain and pluck the living flower. Suzy literally turns an imaginary flower, a painted iris, and finds behind it the chain: the coven that has drugged, steered and killed the academy's daughters. The film performs the critique of religion as a gesture of the hand. Yet what it finds behind the flower is not the economy but the Mother, and the substitution is itself legible. In the Italy in which the film was made, the theorists of Wages for Housework, Mariarosa Dalla Costa and Silvia Federici among them, were arguing that capital rests on a hidden, unwaged reproductive labour performed by women in the home. A house sustained by the unseen body of a woman who sleeps behind a curtain is the Gothic image of that labour.

The third reading is mythological. Iris is the messenger of Juno, goddess of marriage and, as Juno Lucina, of childbirth; she is the rainbow, the full spectrum of the colours the film separates; and in the fourth book of the *Aeneid* Juno, pitying Dido's long agony, sends Iris down to cut a lock of her hair and release her struggling breath into the winds. The fourth reading is cinematic. The iris is the aperture of the eye and the diaphragm of the camera, and the iris that opens and closes on the image was one of silent cinema's first marks of punctuation. The door to the hidden Mother opens when the apparatus of vision opens. A film about the exposure of the invisible makes its key the organ of exposure itself.

The weapon completes the emblem. Suzy kills Markos with the spike of an ornamental glass peacock. The peacock is Juno's bird, and in Ovid's *Metamorphoses* its tail carries the hundred eyes of Argus Panoptes, the all-seeing guardian Juno set over Io; Augustine, who recorded that peacock flesh did not decay, made the bird an emblem of incorruptibility and resurrection. The decrepit Mother, whose house rains maggots, is killed by the emblem of incorruptible, all-seeing vision, an image of the panoptic eye, in the decade in which Foucault's *Surveiller et punir* (1975) made Bentham's Panopticon the diagram of disciplinary modernity. The peacock is also a crystal-plumed bird, and Argento's first film had been *L'uccello*

dalle piume di cristallo (1970), whose title creature is identified by its cry and whose killer proves to be a woman. The auteur's first emblem returns as the instrument of matricide. The film's argument is legible in its props: the daughter kills the Mother with the insignia of the mother-goddess, opening her door with Juno's messenger and piercing her throat with Juno's bird.

2.6

The Acousmatic Mother

Before she is seen, Markos is heard. When the students are moved to sleep in the practice hall after maggots rain from the ceiling, a sheet is hung across the room, and behind it, in silhouette, a figure sleeps with a whistling, laboured breath that Sara recognises as the snore of the directress who is supposed to be away. At the climax Suzy finds her by the same laboured breathing. The Mother is a respiration before she is a body. Michel Chion's *La Voix au cinéma* (1982) supplies the theory. The *acousmêtre*, the voice whose source is withheld from sight, enjoys ubiquity, panoptic vision, omniscience and omnipotence, and loses them at the moment of de-acousmatisation, when the body is shown. Chion's paradigm is Mrs. Bates in *Psycho* (1960), another mother known only as a voice until a swinging light bulb reveals a corpse. Markos belongs to this lineage. Invisible even in her chamber, she taunts Suzy and commands her coven until lightning outlines her body; then she becomes a hag, a throat, a mortal thing.

The score is the acoustic environment of this sovereign breath. Goblin's theme, recorded before shooting and played on set at punishing volume, opens with a lullaby-like figure on the celesta before the band's assault, and the soundtrack saturates the film with whispers, groans and gasps, among them a whispered word for "witch." Julia Kristeva's *La Révolution du langage poétique* (1974) had theorised the semiotic *chora*, a pre-symbolic space of rhythm, drive and maternal sound that erupts through the symbolic order. She took the term from the *Timaeus*, where Plato calls the receptacle of becoming its "nurse" and "mother" and says that it is grasped only by "a kind of bastard reasoning," as in a dream. Goblin's score is a *chora* in this sense: maternal sound, lullaby and breath, invading the visible world. The dream-like apprehension that Plato reserved for the maternal receptacle is precisely the mode in which Argento's film asks to be seen.

The coven's instrument of domination is likewise a matter of the mouth. Suzy, hexed and fainting, is put on a diet of food and wine that keeps her in stupor. Her lucidity returns when she pours the wine away and begins, as Sara had, to count the footsteps of the teachers, which do not leave the building at night but lead deeper into it. The opium of De Quincey's *Confessions* and of Marx's "opium of the people" returns as the wine of the dancers, and the critique of religion is repeated as a refusal to drink. The heroines investigate by ear. In an inversion of Goya's *El sueño de la razón produce monstruos* (1799), it is the monster that sleeps and reason that wakes. The film's model of emancipation is literally Kantian. "What Is Enlightenment?" (1784) defined enlightenment as the exit from

a self-incurred minority (*Unmündigkeit*) and blamed the guardians (*Vormünder*) who persuade the greater part of humanity, "the entire fair sex" among them, that the step to maturity is dangerous. The academy is a school of guardians, and its guardians are women. *Mündigkeit* derives from the old Germanic *munt*, guardianship, though popular speech has long heard in it *Mund*, the mouth: to be *mündig* is to speak for oneself. Suzy becomes *mündig* by refusing what is put into her mouth and finding the throat from which the Mother breathes.

2.7

Two Doctors, Lightning and Fire: Enlightenment as Auto-da-fé

Before the climax the film stages, in two brief consultations, the two modern discourses on the witch. Frank Mandel, the psychiatrist played by Udo Kier, treats belief in witches as pathology: bad luck, he tells Suzy, comes not from broken mirrors but from broken minds. Professor Milius, the scholar of the occult, answers in Latin. Magic, he says, is *quoddam ubique, quoddam semper, quoddam ab omnibus creditum est*: that which has been believed everywhere, always and by all. The formula is a slightly altered form of the canon of Vincent of Lérins (*quod ubique, quod semper, quod ab omnibus creditum est*, c. 434), the rule by which the Church distinguished catholic faith from heresy. The professor defines magic with the definition of orthodoxy. In a film whose ground is the *Malleus*, the effect is to annul the inquisitor's founding etymology. If magic is what has been believed everywhere, always and by all, the witch does not have *fe minus*, less faith, but the most catholic faith of all, and the distinction between religion and witchcraft on which the persecution rested collapses into a difference of institution. Milius tells Suzy, too, that a coven's strength resides in its leader, in its head: the coven is a serpent body governed from a single point.

The head is found by lightning. The film's climactic image fuses the oldest figure of revelation with the master-metaphor of the age that called itself *Aufklärung*, *les Lumières*, *Illuminismo*. Aby Warburg, lecturing in April 1923 to the patients and staff of Ludwig Binswanger's sanatorium at Kreuzlingen on Lake Constance, traced the lightning-serpent of the Pueblo rituals to the copper wire with which Edison had wrested lightning from nature, and warned that the instantaneous connection of modern technology destroys the *Denkraum*, the space of reflective distance that myth and symbol had opened between humanity and its terrors. The 1977 film's lightning is Warburg's electricity. It abolishes the distance between daughter and Mother in the instant before the kill.

Horkheimer and Adorno's *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944/1947) states the logic of the scene: myth is already enlightenment, and enlightenment reverts to mythology. The domination of nature that enlightenment pursues is, in patriarchal civilisation, inseparable from the domination of the woman made to represent nature. The film's ending makes the reversion visible. When Markos dies, Sara's reanimated corpse vanishes, Blanc, Tanner and the coven die in agony, and the house catches fire and explodes; Suzy runs out through the rain and, before

the burning façade, smiles. The final image of the 1977 *Suspiria* is an auto-da-fé without a tribunal: an enlightenment that offers the burning of the witches' house as its proof.

That image has a feminist historiography. Jules Michelet's *La Sorcière* (1862) made the witch the rebel of the Middle Ages, priestess of nature and mother of medicine; Matilda Joslyn Gage's *Woman, Church and State* (1893) made the witch-hunt a war on women; Barbara Ehrenreich and Deirdre English's *Witches, Midwives, and Nurses* (1973) read it as the suppression of women healers; Carolyn Merchant's *The Death of Nature* (1980) tied it to the mechanisation of nature by the scientific revolution; and Silvia Federici's *Caliban and the Witch* (2004), whose research began in the Italian feminism of the 1970s, made it the founding violence of the capitalist sexual division of labour, the enclosure of women's bodies and their reproductive powers. In the years when *Suspiria* was made, Italian feminists marched under the slogan *Tremate, tremate, le streghe son tornate*: tremble, tremble, the witches have returned. The film can be read as the patriarchal unconscious's reply. Its witches have indeed returned, and they are destroyed by fire.

The cinematic genealogy of that fire is exact. Lang's *Metropolis* (1927) ends with the false Maria, the machine-woman who had inflamed the city's men with an erotic dance and its workers with incitement, burned at the stake by the crowd; Benjamin Christensen's *Häxan* (1922) argued that the witches of the past were the hysterics of the present; Dreyer's *Vredens dag* (1943), made under the German occupation of Denmark, recounted the burning of witches as an allegory of persecution and ended with a woman accepting the accusation. The casting of Joan Bennett, star of Lang's American films, as Madame Blanc ties the academy to the director who staged the burning of the false mother. Heine had warned in *Almansor* (1821) that where books are burned, in the end people will be burned too. The 1977 film ends with a burning house in the rain. The 2018 film will begin in the city where, on 10 May 1933, the books were burned.

2.8

Matricide and Its Discontents

The 1977 film's place in feminist thought is ambivalent, and the ambivalence is instructive. On one side stand the conditions of its making and its spectacle. Argento's notorious remark that he would rather watch a beautiful woman being murdered than an ugly woman or a man became, for a generation of critics, the emblem of the giallo's misogyny, and his films return insistently to the revelation that the killer is a mother. In *Profondo rosso* (1975), in which Nicolodi also acted, the murderer is the mother of the hero's friend, decapitated at the end when her necklace catches in a descending lift; in *Inferno* (1980) the Mother of Darkness unmasks herself as Death. Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) had described a cinema in which woman is image and man the bearer of the look; Argento's camera offers instead an impersonal, predatory gaze that belongs to no one and seeks out women's bodies.

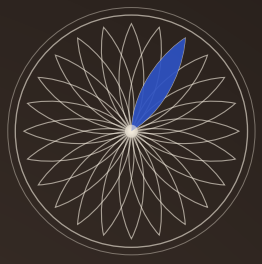
On the other side stands a film whose world is almost wholly female, whose investigators are women and whose heroine looks, deduces and acts. Linda Williams's "When the Woman Looks" (1984) argued that in classical horror the woman's look at the monster is punished because it recognises an affinity: both are freaks before the patriarchal norm. Suzy looks and is not punished; she kills. Carol Clover's Final Girl (1992), the watchful survivor of the slasher, has an Italian ancestor here, and Barbara Creed's *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993) supplies the name of the antagonist: the archaic mother, the abyss from which the subject must separate, figured in the abject matter the film multiplies, from maggots raining from the ceiling to blood welling from the mouth to a room of razor wire. Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980) had already located the first abjection in the separation from the maternal body.

The theoretical crux is matricide itself. Irigaray, in a lecture published in 1981, declared that Western culture rests not on the parricide Freud described in *Totem and Taboo* but on the murder of the mother, and read the *Oresteia* as its charter: Clytemnestra killed, Electra maddened, Orestes acquitted by a motherless goddess. Kristeva, in *Black Sun* (1987), affirmed the opposite with equal force ("Matricide is our vital necessity, the sine-qua-non condition of our individuation"), while observing that for the daughter, who must kill a mother she also is, the act is never clean and its failure returns as depression. Amber Jacobs's *On Matricide* (2007) recovered behind Athena's acquittal of Orestes the occluded matricide of Metis, the pregnant goddess Zeus swallowed, and argued for a maternal law that would permit separation from the mother without her murder. The 1977 *Suspiria* stages Kristeva's necessity in its most masculine form. Its daughter kills the Mother cleanly, in a single thrust, without grief and without remainder; her autonomy is Orestes's, and her smile in the rain is the smile of the acquitted.

Yet the film's genesis contradicts its fable. Its story, by Nicolodi's account, descends from a grandmother's tale told to a granddaughter: a matrilineal transmission of the knowledge that schools may harbour witches. The fable kills the Mother; its transmission passes through the mothers. The 1977 film is a matricidal form carried by a matrilineal content, and its unresolved tension, between a girl's emancipation and the murder that purchases it, between enlightenment and the fire it lights, is the inheritance of the 2018 film. Where Argento's academy burns, Guadagnino's begins: in a city that had burned books, houses and bodies, among women who had kept a house standing through the fire.



CHAPTER THREE



Ecstasy and the Demon

Ausdruckstanz, *the* Volk *and the Choreography of Possession*

VOLK

The most consequential transformation the 2018 film performs on its hypotext is a change of medium. The 1977 academy teaches ballet, and dance there is little more than an alibi: a discipline of verticality glimpsed in fragments of class, in one of which Suzy collapses. The 2018 company dances in the tradition of German *Ausdruckstanz*, the expressive dance of Mary Wigman and Rudolf von Laban, and dance becomes the medium of everything the film means: the coven's power, the transmission of its will, the destruction of its enemies, the formation and the liberation of its heroine. This chapter borrows its title from Susan Manning's *Ecstasy and the Demon* (1993), the study that showed how Wigman's dances articulated at once a feminist subjectivity and a nationalist community. It argues that the 2018 film inherits this double articulation and stages it as a struggle over breath. Modern dance is the art in which a body learns to breathe as its own, and the art in which it can be made to breathe as another's.

3.1 FROM *BALLET BLANC* TO THE TELLURIC BODY

Classical ballet is a court art and a discipline of the vertical. Its codification began with Louis XIV's Académie Royale de Danse (1661); its Romantic apotheosis, in *La Sylphide* (1832) and *Giselle* (1841), raised the ballerina onto pointe and dematerialised her into sylph and ghost. The second act of *Giselle*, which Théophile Gautier drew from the legend of the Wilis that Heine had transmitted in *Elementargeister* (1837), is the archetype of the *ballet blanc*, the white act in which brides who died before their weddings rise at night to dance to death any man they meet. Madame Blanc bears that genre's name. In both films the deputy of the hidden Mother wears the colour of Romantic ballet's ghost-women, the white of maidens who are dead and dangerous. Mallarmé's "Ballets" (1886) gave the classical dancer her philosophy: she is not a woman who dances, he wrote, because she is not a woman but a metaphor, summing up an elemental aspect of form (sword, cup, flower), and she does not dance but writes with her body a poem freed from the scribe's apparatus. The ballerina is a sign.

Foucault's *Surveiller et punir* supplies the institutional complement. The barre, the mirror, the count and the corrective gaze are techniques of the docile body, kin to the drill of the barracks and the timetable of the school. The 1977 academy, where Alida Valli's Miss Tanner barks the time, is such an institution, and Suzy's collapse in class under the coven's hex is a fall from verticality: the body held up as a sign drops as flesh, bleeding from the mouth. *Ausdruckstanz* inverts every term of this regime. It is barefoot rather than shod, telluric rather than aerial; it seeks the floor rather than fleeing it; its source is not the codified position but the inner impulse; its body is not a metaphor but a force. The 2018 film's choreography, created by Damien Jalet, belongs to this lineage, and its camera, which in 1977 had shown dance in fragments, now dwells on weight, effort and breath.

3.2

The Genealogy of the Expressive Body: From Delsarte to Ascona

The expressive body has a genealogy in which breath is the constant. François Delsarte's system of applied aesthetics posited a law of correspondence between each spiritual function and a bodily one; its American disciples, Genevieve Stebbins above all, turned it into a culture of breath (*Dynamic Breathing and Harmonic Gymnastics*, 1892), through which Ruth St. Denis and Isadora Duncan received it. Duncan located the source of movement in the solar plexus, recounting in *My Life* (1927) how she stood for hours with her hands folded over her breast in search of its central spring. In 1903 she lectured in Berlin on *The Dance of the Future*, and in 1904 she opened a school in the Grunewald. After her two children drowned in Paris in 1913, her dancing turned increasingly to lament. One of modern dance's founding manifestos was thus delivered in Berlin by a woman whom grief would make a figure of the *Mater Lachrymarum*.

At Hellerau, the garden city outside Dresden, Émile Jaques-Dalcroze opened in 1911 an institute for his eurhythmics in Heinrich Tessenow's Festspielhaus, where Adolphe Appia's luminous, rhythmic spaces framed the school festivals of 1912 and 1913, the latter a full staging of Gluck's *Orfeo ed Euridice* with the pupils as Furies and Blessed Spirits. Among those pupils, from 1910, was Marie Wiegmann of Hanover, who in 1913 left Dalcroze for Rudolf von Laban's summer school at Monte Verità above Ascona. Founded in 1900 as a vegetarian, naturist and anarchist colony of *Lebensreform*, Monte Verità was the densest laboratory of the century's ecstatic culture. There Laban developed his theory of movement and of the *Bewegungschor*, the movement choir of lay dancers; there, in August 1917, at a congress the occultist Theodor Reuss convened for his order, he staged a ritual dance-drama in praise of the sun; there, in the years before the war, the psychoanalyst Otto Gross had preached matriarchal revolution against the patriarchal family and state. From 1933 Ascona also hosted the Eranos conferences, where Erich Neumann lectured on the archetypal feminine and Gershom Scholem, in 1952, on the Shekhinah, the feminine presence of God who goes into exile with her people. In one lakeside town converged the discourses of the Mother that the 2018 film braids together: ecstatic dance, matriarchal politics, the mythology of the Great Mother and, in Scholem's lecture, the Jewish theology of a feminine divinity who suffers with the persecuted. That last is De Quincey's Lady of Sighs, "the visitor of the Jew," in theological dress, and Chapter Seven returns to it.

3.3 *HEXENTANZ*: THE WITCH WHO DANCED ALONE

Mary Wigman, as she renamed herself, created the first version of her *Hexentanz* in 1914 and a second, the version preserved in a fragment of film, in 1926. She danced it seated or crouching, masked, the torso coiled, the hands clawing, feet and fists striking against a percussion accompaniment: a dance of gravity and compression in which a woman alone appropriates the figure of the demon. In *Die*

Sprache des Tanzes (1963) Wigman recalled catching sight of herself late one night in a mirror, dishevelled and possessed, and recognising in the image the witch, the earth-bound creature of unbridled instinct she had both feared and sought, which she then gave form. Her dictum, "Without ecstasy no dance! Without form no dance!", names the two poles between which *Ausdruckstanz* oscillated. The 2018 film distributes them between the two parties of its coven: ecstasy without form in the devouring will of Markos, form without ecstasy in the institution Blanc has sustained. Susie, in the end, is their synthesis.

Manning's argument is that Wigman's early solos articulated a feminist subjectivity: a woman claiming the demonic, the ecstatic and the ugly as her own, against the ballet's ideal of the ethereal sylph. The witch of *Hexentanz* is not the victim of the stake but a self-portrait of female power. The 2018 film returns to this scene twice. It makes the mirror the site of its most terrible set piece, and it makes its heroine's solo, danced alone in a rehearsal room, the act in which ecstasy becomes a curse. But Manning also traced the second half of Wigman's trajectory, the passage from the solo's "absolute dance" to the group's "German dance," in which the ecstatic female body became the vehicle of a national community.

3.4 *VOLK*: THE MOVEMENT CHOIR AND THE MASS ORNAMENT

The trajectory culminated in the summer of 1936. For *Olympische Jugend*, the festival play performed in the Berlin stadium on the evening the Games opened, Wigman choreographed a *Totenklage*, a lament for the dead, for a chorus of women, while Gret Palucca and Harald Kreutzberg contributed solos. Laban, then head of the Deutsche Tanzbühne, prepared a mass movement choir, *Vom Tauwind und der neuen Freude*, for the open-air theatre built for the Olympics; Goebbels attended the dress rehearsal and banned it, complaining in his diary that it was all intellectual and that it went about in "our" garments while having nothing to do with "us." Laban left Germany the following year. Wigman stayed, relinquished her Dresden school in 1942 for a post in Leipzig and, in 1949, opened a studio in West Berlin, where in 1957 she choreographed Stravinsky's *Le Sacre du printemps* and where she died in 1973. The movement's complicity, long euphemised, was documented by Lilian Karina and Marion Kant in *Tanz unterm Hakenkreuz* (1996) and by Laure Guilbert in *Danser avec le IIIe Reich* (2000). The 2018 company, a female-led modern-dance ensemble in West Berlin whose matrons held it together through the war, is unthinkable without this history, and its Madame Blanc is a composite of Wigman's authority and the later severity of Pina Bausch.

Siegfried Kracauer's "Das Ornament der Masse" (1927) had already diagnosed the form. Watching the Tiller Girls, Kracauer saw bodies dissolved into geometrical patterns that answered to the rationality of the assembly line: the legs of the Tiller Girls corresponded to the hands in the factory, and the ornament, an end in itself, mirrored a capitalist reason emptied of meaning. The Nuremberg rallies and Riefenstahl's *Triumph des Willens* (1935) completed the diagnosis, and Riefenstahl herself had begun as an expressive dancer. Susan Sontag's "Fascinating Fas-

cism" (1975) itemised the aesthetic: the massing of people, their conversion into things, their multiplication and their grouping around a hypnotic leader-figure, together with the celebration of submission, effort and the endurance of pain.

The 2018 company's signature work is called *Volk*. Its dancers are bound in harnesses of red rope; they stamp, convulse and breathe audibly in unison around a central protagonist; and the dancer chosen for that central role is, in the coven's design, the vessel into which the putrefying Markos means to pass. Blanc gives the theory of the transfer in a dictum that is the film's ontology of dance: to dance another's dance is to "make yourself in the image of its creator." The sentence inverts Pico. The humanist Adam is the being without a fixed image, free to give himself form; the dancer of *Volk* surrenders her form to receive another's image. It also rewrites Genesis, in which the creature is made in the image of its creator. In *Volk* the creature is remade in the image of the choreographer, and the *imago* is a possession. The work's name carries the burden of German twentieth-century history: the *Volk* of the *Volksgemeinschaft*, the racial community, and also, in the autumn of 1977 in which the film is set, the "people's prison" (*Volksgefängnis*) in which the Red Army Faction held Hanns Martin Schleyer, president of the employers' federations and a former SS officer, from his abduction on 5 September until his murder on 18 October. *Volk* names the mass that dances around a leader and the word in whose name that mass's children kidnapped and killed. In 1977 alone the RAF murdered the federal prosecutor general Siegfried Buback together with his driver and an official of his office, the banker Jürgen Ponto, Schleyer's driver and the three police officers escorting him, and Schleyer himself. The film refuses to separate them.

3.5

The Arc of Hysteria and the Grammar of Possession

The 2018 film's most notorious sequence fuses dance, hysteria and possession into a single image. Olga, the company's Soviet lead, accuses the matrons of witchcraft and storms out; lost in the building, she finds herself trapped in a mirror-lined studio, and as Susie dances an aggressive solo in the rehearsal room, each of her movements is reproduced as violence on Olga's body, which is thrown, folded and broken, its bones fractured and organs ruptured, until it lies knotted on the floor; the matrons later drag it away on hooks. While Blanc watches Susie dance, the dance's effect is consummated out of sight: the spectacle is admired in one room while a body is destroyed in another. The sequence is the most literal staging in cinema of what James Frazer, in *The Golden Bough* (1890), called homeopathic or imitative magic, governed by the law that like produces like. Its iconography is older and more precise. The arched, dislocated, multiplied body in the mirrored room is the body of the Salpêtrière.

At the Salpêtrière in the 1870s and 1880s, Jean-Martin Charcot theatricalised hysteria in his public lessons and had it photographed in the *Iconographie photographique de la Salpêtrière* (1876–1880) of Bourneville and Régnard: the patients'

"passionate attitudes," their "clownism," their *arc de cercle*, the body bent backward into a bow. Georges Didi-Huberman's *Invention de l'hystérie* (1982) showed that the apparatus of photographic capture co-produced the spectacle it claimed to record. Charcot himself, with Paul Richer, published *Les Démoniaques dans l'art* (1887), diagnosing the possessed of religious painting as hysterics before the letter, and Benjamin Christensen's *Häxan* carried the thesis to the cinema. The medicalisation of the witch was complete: the possessed were hysterics, the witches were patients, and the inquisitor had become the neurologist.

Freud, Charcot's student in the winter of 1885–1886, took the argument a step further and then, decisively, a step back. In January 1897 he wrote to Wilhelm Fliess that the medieval theory of possession held by the ecclesiastical courts was identical with his own theory of a foreign body and a splitting of consciousness, and asked why the confessions of witches under torture resembled so closely what his patients told him in treatment; days later he reported that he had ordered the *Malleus Maleficarum*. The psychoanalyst read the witch-hunters' manual as a casebook. In September of the same year he wrote that he no longer believed in his *neurotica*, abandoning the theory that his patients' symptoms derived from sexual abuse suffered in childhood, frequently at the hands of their fathers, in favour of a theory of phantasy; among his reasons, he wrote, was that the theory obliged him to accuse fathers, his own not excluded, of perversion. Feminist critics, from Florence Rush (*The Best Kept Secret*, 1980) and Judith Herman (*Trauma and Recovery*, 1992) to Jeffrey Masson's polemical *The Assault on Truth* (1984), read the turn as psychoanalysis's founding refusal to believe women's testimony. The 2018 film places that refusal at its centre. Its psychoanalyst, Josef Klemperer, receives from his patient Patricia an account of a coven that he records as delusion. Chapter Five will argue that his education in the course of the film is the reversal of Freud's September letter.

The literature of possession supplies the political grammar of the scene. Michel de Certeau's *La Possession de Loudun* (1970), on the possessed Ursulines of Loudun (1632–1637), showed that possession was a theatre in which an Other spoke through women's bodies and in which theologians, physicians and agents of the state competed to name that Other; the possessed woman's "I" was occupied, and the occupation was a political event. The tradition passed through Aldous Huxley's *The Devils of Loudun* (1952), Jerzy Kawalerowicz's *Matka Joanna od Aniołów* (1961) and Ken Russell's *The Devils* (1971) to Andrzej Żuławski's *Possession* (1981), in which Isabelle Adjani's body convulses in a West Berlin pressed against the Wall. Olga's death is Loudun in a dance studio: a body occupied by another's movement, in a city divided against itself.

3.6

Tarantism and the Land of Remorse

Italian anthropology offers a further frame, apt for an Italian director's reworking of an Italian film. In *La terra del rimorso* (1961), Ernesto de Martino studied the tarantism of the Salento, in which women "bitten" by the tarantula danced for days to fiddles and tambourines in a ritual of possession and cure, and gathered on 29 June at the chapel of Saint Paul in Galatina to drink the water of the saint's well. Their patron was Paul because, in the Acts of the Apostles, he shook a viper from his hand on Malta unharmed: the same Paul whose Epistle to the Romans speaks of the Spirit's unutterable sighing. De Martino's title turns on a pun. *Rimorso* means remorse and also a second bite, the bite that returns. Tarantism was a cultural technique for managing the return of an unresolved past, individual and collective, through a ritual that gave it form.

The theoretical core of de Martino's work, elaborated in *Il mondo magico* (1948) and *Morte e pianto rituale nel mondo antico* (1958), is the "crisis of presence" (*crisi della presenza*): the threat, in moments of extreme negativity such as bereavement, that a person will lose the capacity to be present in history as an acting subject. Magic and ritual, on his account, rescue presence by "dehistoricising the negative" (*destorificazione del negativo*), relocating the crisis to a mythic plane outside history so that the subject may traverse it and return. Ritual lament, which he followed from ancient Greece to the funeral rites of Lucania and the *planctus* of the Virgin, was the paradigm: a technique by which grief was given a form that kept it from devouring the griever.

De Martino's categories illuminate the 2018 coven with uncanny precision. The Markos company is a ritual institution that has survived the century's crises by dehistoricising them. Its matrons kept dancing through the war; in the autumn of 1977 they rehearse while the radio reports hijackings and kidnappings; their sabbath takes place outside history, in a crypt beneath the city, in mythic time. Klemperer, who keeps the record of his wife's deportation and of his patients' testimonies, embodies the opposite technique: presence through history rather than flight from it. Between these poles, dance in the film is neither ritual escape nor historical document. It is a technique of presence whose outcome depends on whom it serves: a cure, as at Galatina, or a possession, as at Loudun.

3.7

After Auschwitz: Breaking the Nose of Every Beautiful Thing

Madame Blanc tells her dancers that they must "break the nose of every beautiful thing." The dictum is the choreographic corollary of Adorno's sentence, written in 1949 and published in 1951, that to write poetry after Auschwitz is barbaric, a sentence Adorno later qualified in *Negative Dialectics* (1966), conceding that perennial suffering has as much right to expression as the tortured have to scream. Blanc's version is more specific than Adorno's. The broken nose is the

classical statue's mutilation, the damage time and iconoclasm inflict on the marble faces of antiquity, and the beauty it breaks is the Greek ideal that Winckelmann defined in 1755 as "noble simplicity and quiet grandeur" (*edle Einfalt und stille Größe*): the ideal that founded German humanism's love affair with Greece and that National Socialism appropriated, in the neoclassical Königsplatz where the 1977 film's blind man dies and in the prologue to Riefenstahl's *Olympia* (1938), where Myron's *Discobolus* comes to life as a German athlete. To break the nose of every beautiful thing is to deface the Winckelmannian statue that German humanism and German fascism had shared.

The 2018 film carries the iconoclasm into its mythology. Its usurping Mother is named Helena and she is Greek: she bears the name of the most beautiful woman in myth in a body riddled with sores and tumours, from which the limbs of unborn infants grow, decaying in the crypt beneath the company. The Winckelmannian Helen has become a corpse that will not die. Whatever else Markos signifies, she is the ruin of the Greek ideal: the beautiful thing whose nose history has broken, still demanding fresh bodies in which to be reborn.

German dance after the war offers two humanist counter-traditions. Kurt Jooss's *Der grüne Tisch* (1932), in which a dancing Death claims every figure of a war launched by diplomats around a green table, was the great anti-war ballet of the Weimar years; in 1933 Jooss refused to dismiss the Jewish members of his company and left Germany for Dartington Hall in England, where Laban later joined him. The 2018 film's Death, a slender female figure who appears at its climax, has an ancestor in Jooss's skeletal choreographer of slaughter. Dore Hoyer, a pupil of Wigman and Palucca, created in *Affectos Humanos* (1962) a cycle of solos on the human passions (vanity, desire, hatred, fear, love) drawn from Spinoza's *Ethics*, whose third part declares that no one has yet determined what a body can do; she took her own life in West Berlin at the end of 1967. Her cycle stands as the humanist answer to *Volk*: a dance of the affects that belong to a person, not a dance through which a person is occupied by another.

Pina Bausch, trained by Jooss at the Folkwang school in Essen, made the Tanztheater Wuppertal, from 1973, the stage on which German dance confronted the violence of its own forms. Her *Das Frühlingsopfer* (1975), danced on a floor of peat, ends as Stravinsky's scenario requires, with the Chosen One, a woman in a red dress, dancing herself to death before the community. Bausch's remark that she was interested not in how people move but in what moves them could stand as the epigraph of the 2018 film, which is obsessed with what moves bodies. *Volk* is a *Sacre* reversed. In Stravinsky, in Wigman's staging of 1957 and in Bausch's of 1975, the community sacrifices its Chosen One; in *Suspiria* the chosen vessel proves to be the divinity, and it is the elders who die.

3.8

Breath as Choreography: Inspiration, Expiration, Conspiration

Across this genealogy one element remains constant: breath. Stebbins's dynamic breathing, Duncan's solar plexus, the phrasing of *Ausdruckstanz* by inhalation and exhalation, the audible exhaustion of Bausch's dancers: modern dance discovered breath as the medium in which an inner impulse becomes an outer form. The 2018 film builds its sound on that discovery. Laboured breathing runs beneath Thom Yorke's "Suspirium" over the opening credits; the dancers of *Volk* breathe percussively; and the climax, as Chapter Seven will show, turns on breath taken and breath released.

Three words of a single Latin root organise the film's choreography of breath. *Inspiratio* is the breath of a god entering a human body, the Pythia's breath at Delphi and the Muse's in the poet; in the 2018 film it names the moment of possession, when a dancer receives the image of the dance's creator. *Exspiratio* is the breath that leaves the body at death; it names the release that Virgil's Iris grants Dido and that the film's Mother will grant those who ask her for it. *Conspiratio* is breathing together: the root of "conspiracy," and therefore the proper name of a coven, but also the oldest name of a chorus, an ensemble, a community whose members share a rhythm of breath. The coven conspires in both senses.

The question the film poses, and which the following chapters pursue, is how to distinguish the conspiration of the *Volk*, in which many breathe as one because one breathes through many, from a conspiration in which each breath remains its own. Freiburg's phenomenology supplies the criterion. Edith Stein, in the dissertation on empathy she completed there in 1916, and Max Scheler, in his phenomenology of sympathy (1913; revised as *Wesen und Formen der Sympathie*, 1923), distinguished empathy from emotional contagion (*Gefühlsansteckung*) and from fusion (*Einsfühlung*). In empathy I live another's experience as *theirs*, given to me non-originally, without appropriating it; in contagion and fusion the boundary between selves dissolves. Possession, the borrowing of bodies that is the coven's economy, is fusion carried to its limit. Luce Irigaray, in *Between East and West* (1999), proposed the cultivation of one's own breath as the condition of an encounter with another that does not appropriate. Between Stein's empathy and Irigaray's breath lies the ethics this dissertation will call conspiration without possession: a breathing-together in which no one breathes through another. *Ausdruckstanz*, which gave Germany both Hoyer's affects and the movement choirs of the *Volk*, was the art in which that difference was danced, and lost; the 2018 *Suspiria* is the film in which it is danced again.



CHAPTER FOUR

Germany in Autumn

Guilt, Debt and the Mütterfilm *(2018)*

SCHUL

The 2018 *Suspiria* moves the fable out of the timelessness of the fairy tale and into the most precisely dated season of postwar German history. Guadagnino announced its subject, years before shooting, as the irresistible force of motherhood; Kajganich set it in the German Autumn of 1977 to examine a generation's guilt and its revolt against its parents' denial, and described the academy as the place where an American receives an education in what a modern fascism might look like. This chapter reads the result as a *Mütterfilm*. In the years around 1977 West German writers produced a *Väterliteratur*, a literature in which sons and daughters interrogated fathers who had served the regime. The 2018 film turns the interrogation toward the mothers: toward women's complicity, toward the maternal institution that survives catastrophe intact, and toward the economy of guilt and debt by which a past is carried forward into bodies that did not commit it.

4.1

Six Acts and an Epilogue in a Divided Berlin

A title card announces the film's architecture as six acts and an epilogue in a divided Berlin, and the titles of its parts compose an argument.

PART	TITLE	RESONANCES
Act One	"1977"	The year of the hypotext's release and of the German Autumn
Act Two	"Palaces of Tears"	The palace of Mater Lachrymarum; the *Tränenpalast*, Berlin's border hall at Friedrichstraße
Act Three	"Borrowing"	Markos's survival on bodies held as credit
Act Four	"Taking"	The collection of the debt: the vessel claimed
Act Five	"In the Mutterhaus (All the Floors Are Darkness)"	The motherhouse of a religious community; the darkness of Mater Tenebrarum; floors that open into pits
Act Six	"Suspiriorum"	A genitive whose missing noun, *Mater*, the act supplies
Epilogue	"A Sliced-Up Pear"	Augustine's pear; Dürer's Madonna with the pear slice; the bisected womb

The titles read as a syntax. The first gives a year, which is also the year in which the hypotext was released: the 2018 film narrates the historical outside of the 1977 film, the Germany that surrounded Argento's sets and that his fable did not admit. Its story begins shortly after 13 October 1977, when a four-member commando of the Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine, acting in support of the Red Army Faction, hijacked Lufthansa Flight 181, in the last weeks of the six

during which the RAF held Hanns Martin Schleyer. It unfolds through the season in which the commando's leader shot the airliner's captain, Jürgen Schumann; in which the federal border police unit GSG 9 stormed the aircraft at Mogadishu on the night of 17–18 October and freed the hostages; in which, the same night, the RAF prisoners Andreas Baader and Jan-Carl Raspe were found dead of gunshot wounds and Gudrun Ensslin hanged in their cells at Stammheim, deaths the authorities ruled suicides and that the surviving prisoner, Irmgard Möller, and the RAF's supporters called murder; and in which the RAF shot Schleyer and left his body in the boot of a car in Mulhouse. The second names a place: the palaces of the Mother of Tears and, for any Berliner, the *Tränenpalast*, the departure hall at Friedrichstraße station in which East and West Berliners parted under the eyes of border guards. The third and fourth name an economy. The fifth names a house: in German usage a *Mutterhaus* is the motherhouse of a religious congregation or of a community of Protestant deaconesses governed by a matron, which is what the film calls its witches. The sixth is a genitive plural with its governing noun withheld, "of sighs," a title waiting for the word *Mater* that its act will supply. The epilogue's emblem is read in section 4.8.

4.2

Germany, Pale Mother

In 1933 Brecht addressed his country as a mother: *O Deutschland, bleiche Mutter!*, a pale mother sitting defiled among the nations, whose sons kill their brothers. In 1980 Helma Sanders-Brahms took the line as the title of *Deutschland, bleiche Mutter*, which opens with the poem read by Brecht's daughter, Hanne Hiob, and tells the war and the postwar through the body of a mother whose face, in the end, is paralysed: the nation's wound written on a maternal face. Between poem and film stands the German Autumn and the collective film made about it, *Deutschland im Herbst* (1978), framed by two funerals, Schleyer's state funeral and the burial of Baader, Ensslin and Raspe in Stuttgart, which the city's mayor, Manfred Rommel, son of Hitler's field marshal, permitted against fierce opposition on the ground that enmity must end with death. Two of the film's episodes bear directly on *Suspiria*. In Rainer Werner Fassbinder's, the director interrogates his own mother, who, pressed on democracy, concludes that the best would be an authoritarian ruler who is thoroughly good, kind and orderly. In the episode written by Heinrich Böll and directed by Volker Schlöndorff, television executives shelve a production of Sophocles' *Antigone* as too inflammatory in a week when the country was debating where its dead enemies might lie. The two episodes frame the alternatives that the 2018 film's ending confronts: a mother's wish for a benevolent sovereign, and Antigone's insistence on the rights of the dead against the city. Hegel, in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807), had called womankind, with Antigone in view, the "eternal irony" of the community.

The women of the RAF stand at the centre of this maternal constellation. Gudrun Ensslin, a pastor's daughter, had a son with Bernward Vesper, son of the

National Socialist poet Will Vesper; Vesper's posthumous *Die Reise*, the founding text of his generation's reckoning with its fathers, appeared in 1977. Ulrike Meinhof, raised by a foster mother after her own mother's death, left her twin daughters to go underground and was found hanged in her cell at Stammheim on 9 May 1976, a death the authorities ruled suicide and her supporters disputed. Earlier, from the isolation wing of the Cologne-Ossendorf prison, under conditions that she and her lawyers denounced as isolation torture and that the authorities defended as security measures, she had written that its silence produced the feeling that one's head was exploding, that the skull must split. When the 2018 film's Mother destroys the usurper's partisans, their heads burst. On 30 July 1977 Susanne Albrecht, the daughter of family friends, came to the door of the banker Jürgen Ponto carrying flowers; Brigitte Mohnhaupt and Christian Klar, who had come with her, shot him in his house. The flower that opens the door onto hidden violence, the key of the 1977 *Suspiria*, had its counterpart in the German summer of the film's release. Margarethe von Trotta's *Die bleierne Zeit* (1981), the story of two pastor's daughters modelled on Gudrun and Christiane Ensslin, made the bond between sisters the form in which the German Autumn could be mourned; the 2018 film's friendship between Susie and Sara, the believer who investigates and dies, belongs to its lineage.

The casting completes the genealogy. The matrons are played by women of the European art cinema of the 1970s and after: Angela Winkler, Schlöndorff and von Trotta's Katharina Blum (1975) and Oskar Matzerath's mother in *Die Blechtrommel* (1979), as Miss Tanner; Ingrid Caven, singer and actress of Fassbinder's films, as Miss Vendegast; Renée Soutendijk and Sylvie Testud. Kajganich prepared by studying the women's literature of the period and Fassbinder's films, and the cinematography took Michael Ballhaus's work for Fassbinder as a reference. The coven is cast from the mothers of the New German Cinema. The *Mütterfilm* is thus also a film about the maternal lineage of a national cinema: the women who carried the screen's reckoning with Germany here play the institution that refuses it.

4.3 *MITTÄTERSCHAFT*: THE COVEN AND THE MOTHERS OF THE FATHERLAND

In 1983 the Berlin feminist Christina Thürmer-Rohr introduced the concept of *Mittäterschaft*, women's co-perpetration: the thesis that women are not only victims of patriarchy but participants who profit from it, consent to it and help reproduce it. The concept divided German feminism and anticipated the dispute historians would call the *Historikerinnenstreit*. Claudia Koonz's *Mothers in the Fatherland* (1987) argued that the regime's separate sphere for women had made them active agents of its project; Gisela Bock, whose study of compulsory sterilisation (1986) documented the regime's assault on women it deemed unfit to bear children, answered that Koonz had misplaced the agency of a system that made motherhood itself an instrument of racial policy. That maternalism was institutional. The regime made Mother's Day a state celebration, from 1938 awarded the

Ehrenkreuz der Deutschen Mutter to prolific "German" mothers, founded the SS's Lebensborn homes in 1935 and placed its women's organisations under a *Reichsfrauenführerin*. It also employed women in the camps. Throughout the autumn of 1977 the longest Nazi trial in the Federal Republic's history was in session in Düsseldorf: the Majdanek trial (1975–1981), whose defendants included women who had served as guards, among them Hermine Braunsteiner-Ryan, whom survivors identified as a participant in the selections that sent women and children at Majdanek to the gas chambers. On 30 June 1981 the court sentenced her to life imprisonment, the only one of the nine defendants convicted of having committed murder herself; a second woman guard, Hildegard Lächert, received twelve years for aiding and abetting murder.

The 2018 coven is a study in *Mittäterschaft*. It is a hierarchy of matrons with a constitution. When the question of leadership arises it votes between Blanc and Markos, and Markos wins the popular vote: the procedure is democratic and its result empowers the destroyer. Immediately afterwards Miss Griffith, the most timorous of the matrons, takes her own life, the only member of the coven whose conscience cannot survive the coven's decision. The matrons' daily life is convivial; they dine, gossip and laugh, and when two police inspectors arrive to investigate Patricia's disappearance, the matrons put them into a trance and, cackling, prod their genitals with a hook, after which the men remember nothing. Arendt's term for the evil she observed at Eichmann's trial (1963), its banality, fits this jollity better than any Gothic register, and her earlier essay "Organized Guilt and Universal Responsibility" (1945) named the structure that sustains it: where everyone is complicit, no one can be singled out and judged. Blanc is the conscientious collaborator. She made the company's art, held it together through the war and serves a leader in whom she does not believe; at the sabbath she senses that something is amiss and hesitates, and Markos all but severs her head. The film grants her neither exculpation nor damnation. It shows an institution that is at once a refuge, a women's community financially autonomous and beyond the reach of the police, and a structure of complicity, and it refuses to separate the two.

Two details of the production make the history material. The matrons' kitchen was modelled on the Frankfurt kitchen of 1926, the rationalised workspace of domestic labour designed by Margarete Schütte-Lihotzky, a communist architect whom the regime imprisoned for her resistance: the coven's reproductive labour is housed in the modernist kitchen of a woman the Reich jailed. And for the sabbath the designers covered the walls of the chamber with braided hair, conceived, in the production designer's words, as "the hair of victims." At Auschwitz-Birkenau and other camps the SS had the hair cut from women prisoners and from the bodies of those murdered in the gas chambers, collected it on the orders of the SS Economic-Administrative Main Office and sold it to German firms, which made it into felt and yarn; the memorial at Auschwitz preserves the hair that the Soviet army found there at liberation. The coven celebrates its rite in a room up-

holstered with the remains of the drowned. The film never shows a camp. It builds one into the walls.

4.4 *SCHULD*: THE CREDITOR MATRIARCHY

The titles of the third and fourth acts, "Borrowing" and "Taking," name the coven's economy. Markos, a body riddled with sores and tumours from which the limbs of infants protrude, survives by borrowing: she draws life from young women's bodies, holding them in reserve as collateral, and the coven's plan is the collection of a debt, the taking of Susie's body as Markos's new vessel. Patricia, Olga and Sara end in the crypt as depleted assets, kept alive past use. The economy has a precise genealogy. In the second essay of *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887), Nietzsche derived the moral concept of guilt (*Schuld*) from the material concept of debt (*Schulden*) and located the origin of conscience in the relation of creditor and debtor, in which the creditor acquires, as compensation, the right to inflict pain on the debtor's body: Shylock's pound of flesh. In "Kapitalismus als Religion" (1921), Walter Benjamin described capitalism as a cult that does not expiate but produces guilt, a religion without dogma whose only rite is the endless creation of debt. Marx, in the first volume of *Capital* (1867), described capital as dead labour that lives, vampire-like, only by sucking living labour. And the third Norn, as Chapter One recalled, is Skuld, whose name is cognate with *Schuld*: the future as debt.

Markos is all of these at once: the creditor who exacts the body, the cult that produces guilt without remission, the dead labour of a past that lives on the living. This structure may be called the *creditor matriarchy*. Its historical analogue is the economy of the Federal Republic, which carried two kinds of *Schuld*. The London Agreement on German External Debts (1953) cancelled roughly half of the country's foreign debt and laid the ground for the economic miracle, while the Luxembourg Agreement (1952) committed it to reparations to Israel: the material debt was negotiated, reduced and serviced. The moral debt, as Alexander and Margarete Mitscherlich argued in *Die Unfähigkeit zu trauern* (1967), was neither paid nor mourned. A population that had loved its *Führer* could not mourn him, and therefore could not mourn his victims, and took refuge in the manic labour of reconstruction. The second generation inherited the unpaid guilt as a debt it had not contracted, and a fraction of it, in the RAF, tried to collect from the fathers by violence. The creditor matriarchy is the Gothic form of this economy: a past that does not forgive, that consumes the young to survive, and whose collectors are the mothers. Against it the film's ending will propose something like the Levitical jubilee, the periodic cancellation of debts: the creditor destroyed, the collateral released into death, the guilt reassigned.

4.5

The Crypt and the Phantom

Beneath the academy the film opens a crypt, and psychoanalysis has a theory of crypts. Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok, Hungarian-born analysts working in Paris, distinguished in 1972 between introjection, the process by which mourning enlarges the self by assimilating the lost object, and incorporation, the fantasy of swallowing the object whole so as not to lose it, which forms within the ego a sealed tomb where the unmourned dead live on. In 1975 Abraham added the concept of the phantom: the gap left in a child by a parent's unspeakable secret, transmitted across generations without ever being spoken. The theory, gathered in *L'Écorce et le noyau* (1978), has become a standard instrument for reading the children of perpetrators, from Dan Bar-On's *Legacy of Silence* (1989) to Gabriele Schwab's *Haunting Legacies* (2010).

The 2018 academy is a crypt in Abraham and Torok's sense. Its matrons practise incorporation literally: they swallow the young to sustain an old body that will not die, and they keep their victims beneath the floor in a state between life and death. Patricia's journals, left in Klemperer's office, are the phantom's voice, a secret speaking through a girl who is no longer there. Markos herself is a past that will not pass, and the phrase has its own German history. In 1986 the historian Ernst Nolte published "Vergangenheit, die nicht vergehen will," the essay that opened the *Historikerstreit*, to argue that the National Socialist past should at last be allowed to become history like any other, relativised by comparison with Soviet crimes. The film takes Nolte's phrase literally and against his intent. The past that will not pass is not a burden imposed on the present by moralists; it is a rotting body in the cellar that demands fresh bodies to survive. Its passing requires not relativisation but death, and the burial, by name, of its victims.

4.6

Ohio: The Mennonite Daughter

Susie Bannion comes from a Mennonite family in Ohio, and the film's flashbacks show a dying mother who rejects her daughter. The detail is not local colour. The Mennonites descend from the Anabaptists of the Radical Reformation, whose first congregation formed in Zurich in 1525 and whose founding confession was adopted at Schleitheim, near Schaffhausen on the Upper Rhine, in 1527. Its author, Michael Sattler, was burned at Rottenburg am Neckar that year, and his wife was drowned; the *Martyrs Mirror* (1660) preserved the memory of their martyrs. Anabaptists were persecuted in the same lands and the same centuries as witches, by the same Catholic and Protestant authorities, and their descendants emigrated, by way of the Rhineland families who helped found Germantown in Pennsylvania in 1683, to the American interior. Susie's journey to Berlin is therefore a return: the daughter of German-speaking heretics comes back to the country her ancestors fled. Dakota Johnson herself observed that the Mennonites came from Germany.

The Anabaptist inheritance also supplies Susie's spiritual grammar. Its central virtue is *Gelassenheit*, yieldedness, the surrender of self-will to God, a term that passed from Meister Eckhart through the radical reformers and that Heidegger, in an address at Meßkirch in 1955, made the name of a releasement toward things. The coven's ontology of dance, in which a dancer yields her form to receive the image of the dance's creator, is a perversion of *Gelassenheit*. Susie, raised to yield, becomes the will that yields to no one. Her mother's rejection completes the figure. At the sabbath Susie renounces her mother, who dies at that moment in Ohio, and the figure of Death whom Susie then summons wears the same face, played by the same performer, Małgosia Bela. The daughter does not kill the mother: she renounces her, and the mother, dying, returns as the daughter's minister, Death obedient to her command. Freud's third casket, the mother who is Death, becomes the instrument of a daughter's sovereignty. Chapter Seven calls this matrigenesis.

4.7

Objection: Kitsch and Death

The most serious objection to the 2018 film has come from critics who judged its history ornamental. Richard Brody, in *The New Yorker*, charged that it forced the Holocaust into a horror film and amounted to Holocaust kitsch; others found its historical signifiers a grab bag of headlines. The objection has a theoretical pedigree. Saul Friedländer's *Reflets du nazisme* (1982) analysed the new discourse on Nazism that had emerged in the 1970s, in films and novels that joined kitsch to death and offered an aestheticised fascination with the regime under the cover of critique; Sontag's "Fascinating Fascism" had warned of the same seduction. A film whose climax is a sabbath of bursting heads in a room lined with braided hair invites the charge.

Three considerations qualify it without dismissing it. First, the film never represents the camps. Theresienstadt is named once, at the end, as a fact delivered to a grieving man; the Holocaust appears as absence, as inscription, as hair in a wall, never as spectacle. Second, the film internalises Friedländer's critique. *Volk*, the beautiful dance that holds its audience while a body is broken in another room, is exactly the aestheticised fascination with domination that Friedländer and Sontag described, staged inside the film as the coven's instrument and offered to the spectator as a trap to be recognised. Third, the film's form is the palimpsest. It does not narrate German history but lays it beneath a fable, so that the fable can be read through it, as the act titles, the casting and the settings ask. The risk remains: the Gothic machinery of the climax courts the fascination it criticises, and the film's resolution, as Chapter Seven argues, is more troubling than its critics noticed. But the troubling element is not its use of history. It is the form of sovereignty with which it answers history.

4.8

A Sliced-Up Pear: The Epilogue in a Divided City

The epilogue's events are few. The academy resumes as though nothing had happened; Blanc is found near death, and the students are told that she has left; Susie visits Klemperer, tells him what became of his wife and erases his memory; and a coda in the present day shows the carved initials of Josef and Anke on the wall of their dacha, unnoticed by its current occupants. The title condenses the ending in an emblem that admits three readings, offered as the controlled overinterpretation announced in the Introduction. The first is Augustinian. In the second book of the *Confessions*, Augustine recalls stealing pears as a boy, not from hunger but for love of the theft itself, and makes the pear the emblem of sin loved for its own sake. Susie, the daughter her mother rejected as something wrong, is in her mother's eyes such a sin. The second is Marian and German. In 1512 Albrecht Dürer painted the *Madonna mit der Birnenschnitte*, the Virgin with the Christ child holding a slice of pear, a fruit that devotion of the period could read as the sweetness of the Incarnation; Dürer also engraved the portrait of Erasmus (1526), so that the humanist whose house fronted the 1977 academy and the Mother whose fruit names the 2018 epilogue meet in the work of one German master. The third is anatomical. The uterus is classically described as pear-shaped, and a pear cut in two figures a bisected womb. Berlin in 1977 is a city cut by a wall, a maternal body divided against itself, and the film ends there, the Mother's work done and the house going on as before.

The resumption is the epilogue's most chilling image, because it is the most historical. The house that carries on as though nothing had happened is the Federal Republic's founding posture: the myth of the *Stunde Null*, the zero hour after which life resumed, and the "communicative silence" in which, as the philosopher Hermann Lübbe later argued, the early Federal Republic absorbed its former Nazis. The film does not condemn the resumption outright, since it is also the condition of the students' survival. It asks what memory survives it, and its answer is the carved initials: a past persisting as an inscription in a wall, legible to the spectator and unread by those who live beside it. The palimpsest with which this dissertation began returns as the film's last image. Who is entitled to read it, and who is permitted to forget it, is the question of the next chapter.



CHAPTER FIVE

Klemperer, or the Last Humanist

TESTIS

Josef Klemperer is the 2018 film's most original invention. The 1977 film offers only his faint outline, divided between its two explanatory doctors, the psychiatrist who diagnoses broken minds and the occultist who cites the canon. Klemperer is an old psychotherapist in West Berlin who listens to a frightened student and records her account as delusion; investigates when she disappears; crosses the Wall to the dacha where he once lived with his wife; is lured by a counterfeit of that wife to the coven's sabbath and made to witness it; and is visited at the end by the Mother, who tells him what became of his wife and relieves him of his memory. This chapter argues that Klemperer is the last humanist: the figure in which the film gathers the resources of the European humanist tradition (reason, empathy, testimony and memory) and measures their limits. He is honoured, as no one else in the film is honoured, with the truth; and he is judged, as the tradition he embodies is judged, insufficient against the power he witnesses.

5.1

The Witness Played by the Witch

Tilda Swinton plays three roles in the 2018 film: Madame Blanc, Helena Markos and Josef Klemperer, the last under the credit "Lutz Ebersdorf." The production maintained until a month after the Venice premiere that Ebersdorf was a real psychoanalyst making his only screen appearance; at the festival Swinton read a letter purportedly from him; she wrote his biography herself, wore a prosthetic penis beneath the costume, and has said that the design was always that something about the identity of the performance should remain unresolved. Ingrid Caven, who plays Miss Vendegast, reportedly believed in Ebersdorf until shooting ended.

The device carries three arguments. The first concerns the gender of testimony. A long juridical and theological tradition, of which the *Malleus* is the extreme instance, discounted women's testimony and credited men's; feminist film theory since Mulvey has described a cinema in which the man bears the look and the woman bears its weight. In *Suspiria* the only male character of consequence, the film's witness and the bearer of the look at the sabbath, is a woman's construction, and his masculinity, prosthetic to the letter, is a performance in Judith Butler's sense (*Gender Trouble*, 1990). Swinton's Orlando, in Sally Potter's film (1992) of Virginia Woolf's novel (1928), the being who passes across centuries and sexes, prepares the figure: Klemperer is an Orlando of witness, a consciousness spanning 1943 and 1977 that no single body exhausts.

The second argument is more troubling. Raul Hilberg's *Perpetrators Victims Bystanders* (1992) gave the historiography of the Holocaust its canonical triad, and Swinton's three roles occupy its three positions: Markos the perpetrator, Blanc the collaborator who serves and does not stop the crime, Klemperer the survivor of a victim and the witness of a rite. One body passes through every position in Hilberg's taxonomy. The film thereby enacts what Primo Levi, in *The Drowned and the Saved* (1986), called the gray zone, in which victim and perpetrator are not essences but positions available to a single humanity. The third argument

is metafictional. As Klemperer is deceived by a performance of his beloved, the audience was invited to believe in a performance of a man. The spectator is placed in the witness's position, credulous before an image of the real that turns out to have been made by the women who govern the film.

5.2

Two Josephs and a Klemperer

The name is a compact of the two humanist sciences of interpretation. In *The Interpretation of Dreams* (1899/1900), Freud remarked that his own ego hid readily behind people named Josef, since Joseph was the name of the man famous in the Bible as an interpreter of dreams; the biblical reader of Pharaoh's dreams is psychoanalysis's ancestor, and Josef is the analyst's name. Klemperer is the philologist's. Victor Klemperer, the Dresden Romanist, kept through the Third Reich the diaries published in 1995 as *Ich will Zeugnis ablegen bis zum letzten* (I will bear witness to the last), and in *LTI – Lingua Tertii Imperii* (1947) recorded the corruption of German by the regime's language. Among its subjects is the word *Volk*, which, he observed, the regime sprinkled over everything it said, as one salts every dish. The 2018 company's signature work bears the word that Klemperer's namesake had already anatomised.

Victor Klemperer survived because his non-Jewish wife, Eva, refused to divorce him, and because the bombing of Dresden in February 1945 allowed the couple to escape days before his scheduled deportation. Josef Klemperer is his inverted mirror. His wife Anke, a Jewish woman in Berlin, warned him for years of the danger the regime posed to her, and he judged her fears unfounded; she was arrested and deported to Theresienstadt, where she died. Victor was saved by a wife who stood by him; Josef outlived a wife he did not believe. The name joins the interpreter of dreams to the witness of language, and the story attached to it records the failure of both: the analyst who read his wife's fear as anxiety, the man of words who did not hear the word that mattered.

5.3

The Analyst Who Did Not Believe

The film opens in Klemperer's consulting room, where Patricia Hingle, distraught, tells him that the academy is governed by a coven, and he records her account as delusion; her journals, left behind in his office, describe the Three Mothers as witches older than Christianity. He has done this before. The man who did not believe his wife's fear of the Nazis does not believe his patient's fear of the coven, and the repetition has the structure of a symptom. In "Remembering, Repeating and Working-Through" (1914), Freud described how what is neither remembered nor worked through returns as action, repeated without being known. Klemperer repeats his failure because he has never worked it through.

The failure has an institutional history, traced in Chapter Three: Freud's letter of September 1897 abandoning the theory that his patients' symptoms derived from abuse suffered in childhood, often at the hands of their fathers, and the feminist critique that read it as psychoanalysis's founding refusal to believe women. Judith Herman's *Trauma and Recovery* (1992) gave that critique its general form. The conflict between the will to deny atrocities and the will to proclaim them, she argued, is the central dialectic of psychological trauma; perpetrators defend themselves first by secrecy and, if secrecy fails, by attacking the credibility of their victims, and they do everything in their power to promote forgetting. The coven's methods follow Herman's account point by point: it washes away every trace of the girls who vanish, puts the investigating police into a trance that leaves them with no memory, and relies on the doctor's disbelief. Released the year after the movement that made "believe women" a public demand, the film traces Klemperer's slow passage from disbelief to belief. He sends the police, who return remembering nothing; he receives Sara, who believes Patricia's journals and descends into the crypt to verify them. The asymmetry of the outcome is the film's judgement on belief: the woman who believes is broken and killed, the man who disbelieved survives. Susie asks, at one point, why everyone is so ready to think the worst is over. The question names the complacency that Klemperer, for all his decency, embodies: the postwar confidence that catastrophe belongs to the past.

5.4

Orpheus Inverted, Pentheus Spared

Klemperer's descent begins in the East. At his dacha beyond the Wall he meets Anke, who tells him that she escaped to England and faked her death; together they walk through a checkpoint into West Berlin without being seen and arrive at the academy, where she is revealed as one of the matrons, Miss Huller, and he understands that he has been brought to witness a sabbath. The scene inverts the myth of Orpheus. In Virgil and Ovid, and in the *Orfeo* that Gluck set and Dalcroze's pupils staged at Hellerau in 1913, the living husband descends to lead his dead wife back to the light and loses her by looking back. Here the dead wife returns to lead the living husband down, and the Wall, the most closely guarded line in Europe, is crossed as the dead cross the Styx, unseen: the second act's "Palaces of Tears" open onto the underworld. Rilke, in "Orpheus. Eurydike. Hermes" (1904), imagined a Eurydice who no longer belonged to the man who came for her and who answered the news of his backward look with the word "Who?" The counterfeit Anke is the complement of Rilke's: a Eurydice who belongs entirely to her husband's desire because she is made of it. The coven builds her from his unmourned grief. Abraham and Torok's phantom is weaponised, and the lesson is political as much as psychological: guilt that has not been worked through becomes a door through which the powerful enter.

At the sabbath Klemperer is held, incapacitated, at the edge of the rite. His position is that of Pentheus in Euripides' *Bacchae* (405 BCE), the king who spies on

the women's rites on Cithaeron, is dressed by Dionysus as a woman and mocked, and is torn apart by his own mother, Agave, who carries his head home believing it a lion's. The film divides Pentheus's fate. The two police inspectors receive its comic half, mocked, emasculated and sent away without memory. Klemperer receives its tragic half without its consummation. He is made to see what men were forbidden to see, exposed to the women's look while compelled to look himself, and the rite's decapitations, Blanc's near-severed neck and the bursting heads of Markos's partisans, take place around him. The Mother does not tear him apart. She sends him home.

5.5

The Last Humanist

Klemperer embodies, in a single frail body, the virtues that European humanism set against barbarism. He listens, with the patience Edith Stein theorised as empathy; he keeps records, his notebooks a counter-archive to the coven's erasures; he remembers, returning to the dacha and its carved initials; he investigates, appeals to the law and tries, belatedly, to protect two young women. He is decent. And he can do nothing. He is old, alone and without power, and at the decisive moment he can only watch. The film honours him as it honours no one else and judges, through him, the sufficiency of what he represents.

The judgement has a history in the literature of the camps. Jean Améry, in "At the Mind's Limits" (1966), recounted how, in Auschwitz, the humanist culture of the intellectual offered no help: lines of Hölderlin that he had loved, recited in the camp, no longer transcended the reality around him. Primo Levi wrote that the true witnesses were the drowned, who had touched bottom and not returned, and that the survivors spoke in their place by proxy. Giorgio Agamben's *Remnants of Auschwitz* (1998) made this lacuna the structure of testimony as such: the survivor bears witness to what he did not undergo, and the one who underwent it cannot speak. Klemperer's testimony has such a lacuna at its centre. He does not know how Anke died. His grief is a story without an ending, and his guilt fills the place where the ending should be.

The film fills the lacuna with the Mother. In the epilogue Susie, now revealed as Mater Suspiriorum, tells him that Anke died at Theresienstadt. The Mother of Sighs knows what no human witness could report. She is the archive of the drowned, "the visitor of the Jew" in De Quincey's phrase, who has been where the victims were. This is the film's most daring proposition and its most problematic: that the lacuna of testimony can be closed only by a power beyond the human. The humanist can witness, record and mourn, but he cannot know how the story ended; the goddess can. The film's anti-humanist temptation, examined in Chapter Seven, begins here, in an act of mercy.

5.6

"But Not Yours": Guilt Reassigned, Memory Erased

Before she touches him, Susie apologises for what her coven has done and tells him: "We need guilt, Doctor. And shame. But not yours." Karl Jaspers's *Die Schuldfrage* (1946) supplies the categories in which the sentence becomes legible. Jaspers distinguished criminal guilt, judged by courts; political guilt, borne by the citizens of a state for its acts; moral guilt, judged by conscience; and metaphysical guilt, the guilt of being alive when others were murdered in one's presence or with one's knowledge, whose only jurisdiction, Jaspers wrote, is God. Klemperer bears no criminal or political guilt. His guilt is moral in part, for the warnings he dismissed, and metaphysical above all: the survivor's guilt that the psychiatrist William Niederland described in the 1960s as a syndrome of those who outlived the persecuted. Susie's sentence is a verdict pronounced in the court that Jaspers reserved for God. It affirms that guilt and shame are necessary, that a society which has done what Germany did requires them; and it reassigns them to those who exercised power, the perpetrators and the complicit, not to the man whose wife they killed.

Then she erases his memory. He suffers a violent seizure, and the film leaves undecided how far the erasure reaches: whether it removes only the night of the sabbath or the whole burden of the past, Anke included. The present-day coda, in which the couple's initials remain unread on the wall of the dacha, suggests the second, a memory that survives only as an inscription no one reads. The gesture has two genealogies, and they pull in opposite directions. Nietzsche praised active forgetting as a condition of health, the temporary closing of the doors and windows of consciousness so that life can go on, and warned in 1874 against an excess of history that kills the living. Paul Ricoeur, in *La Mémoire, l'histoire, l'oubli* (2000), distinguished the forgetting that heals, a reserve from which memory can be recovered, from the commanded forgetting of amnesty, which risks becoming amnesia. Nicole Loraux's *La Cité divisée* (1997) studied the first such command in the West, the amnesty by which Athens, divided by civil war, swore in 403 BCE not to recall past wrongs; her *Les Mères en deuil* (1990) showed that the city had long feared the grief of mothers, whose mourning would not forget (*alaston penthos*) and whose wrath threatened the civic order founded on forgetting. In the 2018 epilogue the roles are inverted. The Mother of Sighs, whose grief should be the one that does not forget, decrees forgetting for the witness, while the institution carries on. Herman's warning stands against the gesture: forgetting is the perpetrator's first defence. The Mother uses the coven's own instrument as her mercy.

Nor is the gesture forgiveness. Simon Wiesenthal's *Die Sonnenblume* (1969) recounts a dying SS man's plea for a Jew's forgiveness and Wiesenthal's silence; Vladimir Jankélévitch declared that forgiveness died in the death camps; Jacques Derrida argued that forgiveness, if it exists, forgives only the unforgivable and cannot be granted by a third party in the victim's name. Susie forgives no one.

She annihilates the perpetrators, gives the witness the truth, relieves him of a guilt that is not his, and then relieves him of the memory that bore it. Her justice is not forgiveness but triage: death to the guilty, truth and release to the witness, death to those who ask for it. Whether that triage is a gift, or the final stroke under the past, the *Schlussstrich* that frees a society from its history by freeing its last witness from his memory, is the question Chapters Six and Seven must answer.



CHAPTER SIX



The Witch between Feminism and Humanism

A Comparative Constellation

STREGA

The witch stands at the junction of the two traditions this dissertation brings into contact. For early modern humanism she is the anti-human: the creature who surrendered the will that Pico made the mark of human dignity, and who could therefore be burned. For modern feminism she is the emblem of a persecuted female knowledge and power, from Michelet's rebel to the collective that hexed Wall Street on Halloween 1968 under the name W.I.T.C.H., the Women's International Terrorist Conspiracy from Hell, an acronym that already joined the vocabulary of conspiracy to that of terror. The witch also exposes the logic of humanism's universal, which was built by exclusion. Aimé Césaire's *Discours sur le colonialisme* (1950) argued that what the humanist bourgeoisie of Europe could not forgive Hitler was not the crime against humanity as such but its application to Europeans of colonial procedures previously reserved for others; Frantz Fanon's *Les Damnés de la terre* (1961) closed with a call to leave a Europe that never stopped speaking of Man while murdering men wherever it found them. Witch, colonised and Jew are successive names for the remainder that humanism's definition of the human produced. Between these poles, the two *Suspiria*s take positions that only comparison can make precise. This chapter assembles a constellation of feminist and humanist works around six problems the films share: the disbelieved woman, the mother's house, the borrowed body, the mother who kills to save, the goddess and her critics, and the dance of the community.

6.1

The Two Disbeliefs

Humanism's finest hour in the history of the witch-hunt was an act of disbelief. Johann Weyer, physician to the Duke of Cleves, argued in *De praestigiis daemonum* (1563) that the women accused of witchcraft were melancholic and deluded, in need of medicine rather than fire. Reginald Scot's *The Discoverie of Witchcraft* (1584) mocked the credulity of the prosecutors. Montaigne, in "Des boiteux" (*Essais* III.11, 1588), wrote that it is putting a very high price on one's conjectures to have a human being roasted alive on their account. Friedrich Spee, a Jesuit who had accompanied the condemned to the stake, published anonymously the *Cautio Criminalis* (1631), demonstrating that torture produced exactly the confessions it sought; Christian Thomasius's *De crimine magiae* (1701) helped bring the trials to an end in Prussia. Humanist scepticism saved women by disbelieving their accusers, and Weyer's medical reading leads, through Charcot, to the 1977 film's psychiatrist, for whom misfortune comes from broken minds.

The same scepticism, turned on the women themselves, became the second disbelief. Freud's letter of September 1897 has been discussed. His case history of "Dora" (1905) concerned Ida Bauer, who at fourteen had been sexually accosted by Hans Zellenka, a friend of her father's. Her father, who was conducting an affair with Zellenka's wife, dismissed her account and brought her to Freud, and she came to believe that she was being handed to Zellenka as the price of the affair. Freud accepted her account of the events but interpreted her disgust as the re-

pression of desire, and the case became for feminist criticism the paradigm of the analyst who does not believe; Hélène Cixous restored Dora as a rebel in *Portrait de Dora* (1976), and in *La Jeune Née* (1975) Catherine Clément read the sorceress and the hysteric as twin figures of women's revolt and of its recapture by the order it disturbs. Charlotte Perkins Gilman's "The Yellow Wallpaper" (1892), whose narrator's physician-husband prescribes rest and dismisses her illness, ends with her tearing the paper to free the women she sees creeping behind its pattern. Jacques Tourneur's *Cat People* (1942) gave the disbelieving analyst his cinematic fate: the psychiatrist Louis Judd treats Irena's conviction that she descends from a Serbian village of witches as a neurosis, attempts to seduce her and is killed by what he disbelieved. Christa Wolf's *Kassandra* (1983) made the prophetess whom no one believes the narrator of the Trojan War, and gave her a refuge among women who worship Cybele on the slopes of Mount Ida, a maternal counter-community outside the citadel at war.

Klemperer is the heir of both disbeliefs: the humanist who would never burn a witch, and the analyst who will not believe a woman. The 2018 film rejects both. Its witches are real, so that belief in Patricia's testimony coincides with belief in what sounds impossible. The fantastic premise literalises a feminist epistemology. What women report may sound like delusion and still be true; the error lies not in credulity toward demons but in incredulity toward women.

6.2

The Mother's House: The Female Gothic

Ellen Moers coined the term "Female Gothic" in *Literary Women* (1976), a year before the 1977 film, to describe the tradition inaugurated by Ann Radcliffe's *The Mysteries of Udolpho* (1794), in which a travelling heroine explores the dark house of a patriarch, and she read Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) as a birth myth written by a daughter whose mother, Mary Wollstonecraft, had died days after bringing her into the world. Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's *The Madwoman in the Attic* (1979) read the confined madwoman as the woman writer's double. Shirley Jackson extended the tradition into the twentieth century. In *The Haunting of Hill House* (1959) Eleanor, who has spent her youth nursing a mother whose knocking on the night of her death she believes she ignored, is absorbed by a house that calls her home. In *We Have Always Lived in the Castle* (1962) two sisters, suspected of poisoning their family, survive the burning of their house and an assault by the villagers, and live on in its ruin while the villagers, ashamed, leave offerings of food at the door. Angela Carter's "The Bloody Chamber" (1979) rewrote Bluebeard so that the bride is saved not by her brothers but by her mother, who rides to the castle and shoots the husband. Jennifer Kent's *The Babadook* (2014) ends with a widowed mother feeding, in the cellar, the creature that embodies her unmourned grief.

Against this tradition the two films take opposite courses. The 1977 film is a Radcliffean Gothic of exposure: the heroine explores the house and discovers its

secret, which is not explained away but proves real, and which is the Mother. Its ending resembles Jackson's burning castle, except that the women inside are the witches and do not survive, and the heroine walks away. The 2018 film is a Gothic of inheritance. Its heroine comes to the house not to escape it but to claim it; the crypt is neither sealed nor fed, as in *The Babadook*, but emptied; and the rescuing mother of Carter's tale is the daughter herself. The tradition's characteristic object, the wall that conceals a woman (Gilman's paper, the 1977 film's painted irises), becomes in 2018 a wall made of women, braided from the hair of victims.

6.3

A Borrowed Silhouette: The Mendieta Affair

The 2018 film's paratext adds an uncomfortable episode to the history of borrowed bodies. In September 2018 the estate of the artist Ana Mendieta sued Amazon Studios, alleging that two images in the film's teaser trailer derived from Mendieta's *Untitled* (*Rape Scene*) (1973) and from her *Silueta* series (1973–1980), and that further images in the film bore similarities to her work; the images in question did not appear in the theatrical trailer, and the parties settled two days before the American release. This dissertation does not adjudicate the claim. Its structural irony, however, is exact. Mendieta's *Siluetas* pressed the outline of her body into earth, sand, mud and flowers, set it alight and marked it in blood: an art in which a woman's body is present as the trace of its vanishing, a silhouette that testifies to violence by absence. The 1977 film had revealed its Mother as a silhouette outlined by lightning. And a film about a coven that survives by borrowing women's bodies, whose screenwriter had researched the feminist art of the 1970s, was accused of borrowing a woman artist's images of her own violated and absent body. The economy that the film criticises was alleged to have operated in its own making.

6.4

The Mother Who Kills to Save

The 2018 Mother's gift of death has a feminist literature, and it is a literature of mothers. Toni Morrison's *Beloved* (1987) drew on the case of Margaret Garner, who in 1856 fled from slavery in Kentucky across the Ohio River to Cincinnati and, when the slave-catchers came, killed her daughter rather than see her returned to bondage. Morrison's Sethe commits the same act out of a love that the novel neither excuses nor condemns, and is haunted by the daughter who returns. The haunting ends when thirty women of the community gather before the house and raise a sound older than words, a collective cry that breaks the spell. The house of *Beloved* stands, like Susie's childhood home, in Ohio. Christa Wolf's *Medea: Stimmen* (1996) rehabilitated the archetypal witch-mother. Her Medea does not kill her children; the city of Corinth, to conceal its own crime, the sacri-

fice of the king's daughter, makes her its scapegoat and lets her children be stoned. The witch-mother is the alibi of a city's secret, which is the structure of the 2018 film's crypt. Ingeborg Bachmann's unfinished *Der Fall Franza*, abandoned in 1966 and published posthumously, follows a woman whose psychiatrist husband has made her a "case" to Egypt, where she seeks out a former SS doctor hiding in Cairo and confronts him with a demand for the lethal injection that physicians of his kind had administered; it is the perpetrator who flees. Bachmann, who held that fascism begins in the relation between a man and a woman, placed in one scene the psychiatrist's case-making, the National Socialist doctor's "mercy" and a woman's demand for death.

The 2018 film belongs to this constellation. When Patricia, Olga and Sara, their bodies ruined by the matrons and, in Olga's case, by Susie's own dance, ask to die and the Mother grants it, maternal mercy and murder become indistinguishable from outside, as they are in Sethe's act and Franza's demand. Chapter Seven argues that the film distinguishes them by request and by interest, and asks whether that distinction holds.

6.5

Goddess, Cyborg and the Symbolic Order of the Mother

The feminist tradition divides over the humanist inheritance. Mary Wollstonecraft's *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (1792) claimed for women the reason that humanism had reserved for men; Simone de Beauvoir's *The Second Sex* (1949) claimed for them the transcendence that existentialist humanism ascribed to the subject, and dismantled the myth of the Eternal Feminine, Goethe's *Ewig-Weibliche*, as a projection serving men. The 1970s produced the opposite movement, a feminism of the goddess. Merlin Stone's *When God Was a Woman* (1976), Mary Daly's *Gyn/Ecology* (1978), which read the European witch-hunt as a ritual of gynocide and reclaimed the names Hag, Crone and Spinster, Carol P. Christ's "Why Women Need the Goddess" (1978) and Starhawk's *The Spiral Dance* (1979) proposed a female divine as the condition of women's spiritual and political autonomy, the programme Irigaray would formulate philosophically in "Divine Women" (1984).

The critiques came quickly. Angela Carter, in the preface to *The Sadeian Woman* (1979), wrote that "mother goddesses are just as silly a notion as father gods," consolations that obscure the real conditions of women's lives. Donna Haraway closed "A Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) with a sentence aimed directly at Starhawk's title: though both are bound in the spiral dance, she would rather be a cyborg than a goddess. Italian feminism proposed a third way. The Milan Women's Bookstore Collective's *Non credere di avere dei diritti* (1987) and Luisa Muraro's *L'ordine simbolico della madre* (1991) theorised *affidamento*, entrustment, the practice by which a woman recognises the authority of another woman as a mediation of her own freedom, and distinguished such authority, relational and symbolic, from power, which coerces. Adriana Cavarero's philosophy of the voice and of

the narratable self supplied its ethics: each person is unique, and that uniqueness is given in a breathing voice and in a life-story that only another can tell.

The 2018 coven can be mapped onto these positions with some precision. The bond between Blanc and Susie is *affidamento*: from the audition Blanc recognises Susie, and Susie entrusts herself to Blanc's authority. Markos is power without authority, the goddess turned into a cult that feeds on its worshippers. The coven's election substitutes majority power for authority and chooses Markos. Julia Kristeva's "Le Temps des femmes" (1979), written in the aftermath of the German Autumn, supplies the diagnosis of this structure. Kristeva observed the large number of women in the terrorist groups of the decade, from the Baader-Meinhof group to the Red Brigades, and argued that the feminist "counter-society," a society of women defined against the symbolic order, risks offering a programme of liberation "more oppressive, more sacrificial" than the order it attacks. Her proposed third generation of feminism would interiorise the separation rather than build a counter-society on it. Later scholarship on the women of the RAF, from Patricia Melzer's study of motherhood in the group (2015) to Katharina Karcher's work on femininity as camouflage (2017), and the history of the Rote Zora, the feminist militant group formed in the mid-1970s, have since complicated Kristeva's psychoanalytic account. Her diagnosis nonetheless describes the 2018 coven exactly: a society of women outside the law whose order is more sacrificial than the patriarchal order it evades. Susie's final position conjoins Muraro's authority (Blanc's recognition, the Mother's title) with power (Death at her command). The film passes through Muraro's distinction and dissolves it. It gives the goddess back, as Daly and Starhawk demanded, and shows in Markos what Carter and Haraway feared the goddess would become.

6.6

The Coven Returns: Matriarchal Horror, 2014–2018

The 2018 *Suspiria* appeared at the end of a cycle in which the coven returned to horror cinema as the ambivalent figure of women's power. Robert Eggers's *The Witch* (2015) follows the daughter of a Puritan family of radical separatists, blamed by her mother for the family's catastrophe, who kills her mother in self-defence and, invited to "live deliciously," joins a coven that rises naked into the night air around a fire. Ari Aster's *Hereditary* (2018) shows a matrilineal cult that uses the women and children of one family to obtain a male host for a male demon, and ends in decapitation and coronation. Anna Biller's *The Love Witch* (2016) recreated the saturated palette of 1970s exploitation cinema, the palette of the 1977 *Suspiria*, to turn the witch's seduction into a critique of the male fantasies that had made her.

The comparison sharpens the 2018 film's position. Like Eggers's heroine, Susie is the daughter of a radical Protestant sect and is rejected by her mother; unlike her, she does not kill her mother but renounces her, and she joins the coven only to take its head. Like *Hereditary*, the film turns on a coven, a vessel and an inheri-

tance; unlike it, the coven serves a Mother rather than a male king, and the vessel refuses to be one. The three films appeared in the years in which the #MeToo movement made the credibility of women's testimony a public question, and all three answered the question of women's power with a witch. Only *Suspiria* asked what that power owes to the dead.

6.7

Clearing and Coven: Two Dances of the Community

The richest counter-model to *Volk* is found in *Beloved*. Baby Suggs, an unchurched preacher who has bought her freedom, calls the community to a clearing in the woods. She asks the children to laugh, the men to dance and the women to weep, until the three mingle; then she preaches a sermon of the flesh, telling her listeners that those who enslaved them do not love their flesh and that they must love it themselves: "Love it. Love it hard." Laughter, dance and tears: the Clearing reunites, in a liberating rite, the elements that the Ladies of Sorrow divide and that the coven perverts, the matrons' cackling, the possessed dance and the drowned weeping. But the Clearing differs from the coven in the decisive respect. No body is borrowed there; no dancer is remade in another's image; each person learns to love her own flesh in the presence of others. It is a conspiration without possession, the communal breath of people who remain themselves.

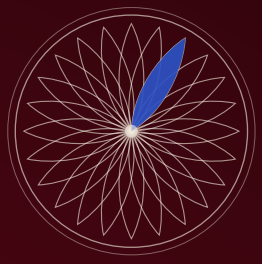
The constellation thus locates the two *Suspiria*s precisely. The 1977 film belongs with the Female Gothic of exposure and with the humanist disbelief that saves by unmasking, and it ends, like the witch-hunt, in fire. The 2018 film belongs with the literature of mothers who kill to save, with the goddess feminism of the 1970s and with Kristeva's counter-society, and it ends with a sovereign. Its feminism is neither the humanist feminism of Wollstonecraft and Beauvoir nor a simple feminism of the goddess. It is a feminism of the Mothers whose criteria are humanist (testimony believed, consent respected, the young released from the debts of the old) and whose agent is a goddess. Humanist ends pursued by superhuman means: that paradox is the subject of the next chapter.



CHAPTER SEVEN

Mater Suspiriorum

Matrigenesis and Suspirial Sovereignty



MATER

The preceding chapters reconstructed genealogies, histories and comparisons. This chapter states the dissertation's theoretical proposition. It defines two concepts: *matrigenesis*, the process by which the 2018 film's daughter accedes to subjectivity by becoming the Mother rather than by killing her; and *suspirial sovereignty*, the form of power the Mother exercises when she answers the sigh. It then submits both to critique, and finds in the critique the ground of the position the Conclusion proposes.

7.1

From Matricide to Matrigenesis

The 1977 film's structure is matricide: the daughter finds, illuminates and kills the Mother, and her autonomy is purchased by the murder, as in Neumann's dragon fight and in the acquittal of Orestes. The 2018 film's structure has four moments. First, renunciation without murder: at the sabbath Susie renounces her mother, who dies in Ohio at that moment, and no blow is struck. Second, return: the dying mother comes back as Death, whom Susie summons and who wears the mother's face, so that the mother survives as the daughter's minister. Third, the annihilation of a usurper: Markos claims a title that is not hers, a counterfeit Mother in the lineage of Stesichorus's phantom Helen and of Lang's false Maria, and she is destroyed. Fourth, inheritance: the true Mother takes the house. Matrigenesis names this sequence. It is the genesis of the subject as Mother, in which a daughter accedes to subjectivity not by separating herself from the maternal through murder but by assuming the maternal position, releasing the mother who bore her and destroying the one who usurped the title. Its theoretical warrants are Amber Jacobs's maternal law, which seeks separation from the mother without her murder; Irigaray's call for a divine in women's image; and Muraro's symbolic order of the mother. It differs from all three in one decisive respect: the daughter's own body becomes the divine.

Christian theology knows the paradox that matrigenesis inverts. Dante's Bernard opens the last canto of the *Paradiso* with the words *Vergine Madre, figlia del tuo figlio*: virgin mother, daughter of your son, the mother engendered by her child. In matrigenesis the daughter becomes mother of herself. Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) supplies the political meaning of such a birth. Natality, the fact that human beings are born and can therefore begin something new, is for Arendt "the miracle that saves the world" from its natural ruin, and she grounds it in Augustine's sentence *initium ut esset homo creatus est*, that there might be a beginning, man was created. Matrigenesis is a natality of the Mother: the birth of a beginning that interrupts the creditor's past. The Mother is not inherited as a debt; she is born as an event.

The climax gives the birth its image. Susie tears open a wound in her own chest. The *Mater Dolorosa*'s heart is pierced from outside, by Simeon's prophecy (Luke 2:35) and by the sword of another's death; Susie opens hers from within. The chest holds the lungs, so that the Mother of Sighs exposes the organ of breath,

and she does so before Death, who wears her mother's face. The scene is a birth at which the mother, as Death, attends as midwife: Freud's third casket, the mother who is Death, becomes the midwife of the daughter's motherhood. Chapter One promised the conversion of the wound into an organ of breath and birth. This is the image in which the film performs it.

Guadagnino has spoken of the psychoanalytic figure of the terrible mother and of the goddess Kali. In the *Devī Māhātmya*, the goddess defeats demons who have usurped the sovereignty of the gods, and Kālī drinks the blood of Raktabīja, each drop of which would otherwise spawn a new demon. Susie's violence is Kālī's in this precise sense: it ends a self-reproducing sovereignty of consumption, Markos's economy of borrowed bodies, which would otherwise renew itself in each new vessel. A caution is in order. The Western reading of Kālī as an archetype of the terrible mother, Neumann's above all, flattens a goddess of a living devotional tradition; the reference indicates the film's ambition rather than its ethnographic accuracy.

7.2

The Sigh as a Political Category

The founding scene of a sovereignty that answers a sigh is in Exodus: "the children of Israel sighed by reason of the bondage, and they cried, and their cry came up unto God by reason of the bondage. And God heard their groaning, and God remembered his covenant" (2:23–24). Liberation precedes law; Sinai follows Egypt. In Lamentations, Jerusalem speaks as a widowed mother-city: "They have heard that I sigh: there is none to comfort me" (1:21). In Romans the whole creation groans in the pangs of birth and the Spirit intercedes with unutterable sighing. Marx made the sigh of the oppressed creature both an expression of misery and a protest against it; De Quincey made the Lady of Sighs the visitor of the Pariah and the Jew; Scholem described the Shekhinah, the feminine presence of God who goes into exile with her people and weeps with them. Across these texts the sigh is the sign of oppression and an appeal, the mourning of a mother-city, the labour of a world being born, and the occasion of a feminine divinity's solidarity with the persecuted.

Walter Benjamin made the sigh historical. In the second of his theses "On the Concept of History" (1940), he asked whether a breath of the air that surrounded those who came before does not brush against us, and whether the voices we heed do not carry an echo of voices now silent; there is, he wrote, a secret agreement between past generations and ours, and we have been endowed with a weak messianic power on which the past has a claim. In the sixth thesis he warned that not even the dead will be safe from the enemy if he wins. The past breathes on the present and claims it. The 2018 film makes this its theory of history: the dead claim the living, the claim takes the form of breath, and the film's title, its act titles and the hair in its walls are the forms of that claim.

The sigh also marks the limit of humanism's definition of the human. In the first book of the *Politics*, Aristotle distinguished the voice (*phōnē*), which animals share and which signals pain and pleasure, from speech (*logos*), which belongs to humans alone and declares the just and the unjust. The humanist tradition inherited the definition of the human as the animal possessing *logos*. The sigh is *phōnē*, not *logos*: the voice of pain beneath speech. Jacques Rancière's *La Mésentente* (1995) located the political wrong in the division by which some are counted as making only noise, and defined politics as the moment when those who have no part make their noise heard as speech. Cavarero's *A più voci* (2003) restored the unique, breathing voice that precedes and exceeds *logos*. A politics of the sigh hears the *phōnē* of the creature as a claim, not only the *logos* of the citizen. That is the root both of suspirial sovereignty and of the alternative to it.

7.3

Suspirial Sovereignty

The modern theory of sovereignty offers three paradigms. For Carl Schmitt (*Politische Theologie*, 1922), sovereign is he who decides on the exception. For Michel Foucault, in his lectures of 1976 and the first volume of *The History of Sexuality* (1976), the classical sovereign's right to take life or let live was transformed by biopower into the power to make live and let die. For Achille Mbembe ("Necropolitics," 2003), sovereignty is the capacity to dictate who may live and who must die; for Giorgio Agamben (*Homo Sacer*, 1995), the sovereign exception produces bare life. All four take life as sovereignty's object and decision as its mode.

The sovereignty that the 2018 film installs differs in object, mode and act. Its object is breath (*pneuma*): the life of the creature as respiration, neither the bare life of the camp nor the political life of the citizen. Its mode is response: it is summoned by a sigh, as the God of Exodus answers a groaning, rather than deciding on its own initiative. Its acts are three gifts and one violence. The first gift is death (*exspiratio*) to those who ask for it: Patricia and Sara, whose bodies the matrons have ruined (they kept Patricia in the catacombs between life and death and cut Sara open at the start of the sabbath), and Olga, whose bones were broken by Susie's own dance. In the fourth book of the *Aeneid*, Juno, pitying Dido's long agony and difficult death, sends Iris to release her struggling breath into the winds. In 1977 the iris opened a door onto a killing; in 2018 the Mother performs the office of Iris. The second gift is testimony to those who mourn: Klemperer learns what became of Anke, and the drowned are restored to the "books of remembrance" from which De Quincey's outcasts had been blotted out. The third gift is forgetting to those whose guilt is not their own: Klemperer is relieved of the survivor's guilt and of the memory that bore it. The one violence is the annihilation of the usurpers, Markos and her partisans.

Benjamin's "Zur Kritik der Gewalt" (1921) supplies the matrix in which these acts can be read. Mythic violence makes law and preserves it; it is bloody, it imposes guilt and expiation at once, and it demands sacrifice. Its emblem is Niobe,

the mother whose children Apollo and Artemis kill and who is left alive, weeping, turned to stone, a mute bearer of guilt and a boundary marker. Divine violence destroys law; it expiates, it is lethal without shedding blood, and it accepts sacrifice rather than demanding it. Its emblem is the earth that swallows the company of Korah. Benjamin called it, in his last sentence, *die waltende*, the sovereign violence. The coven's regime is mythic violence in Benjamin's exact terms: it demands sacrifice (the vessel), it binds its subjects in guilt and debt, and its emblem is the weeping mother turned to stone, the Mater Lachrymarum petrified. Susie's act is divine violence: it destroys the coven's law, it releases the witness from guilt that is not his, and it accepts the sacrifice that Patricia, Olga and Sara offer when they ask to die. One discrepancy remains. Benjamin's divine violence strikes without blood, while Susie's sabbath floods the chamber with it and bursts the heads of her enemies. The film cannot imagine divine violence without the spectacle of mythic violence, and the contamination is where critique begins.

The concept can now be defined. Suspirial sovereignty is the power that answers the sigh. Its object is the breath of the creature rather than the life of the citizen or the body of the population; it acts in response to an appeal rather than by decision on an exception; and it distributes three gifts (death to those who ask for it, testimony to those who mourn, forgetting to those whose guilt is not their own) and one violence (the annihilation of the usurpers). It is the 2018 film's answer at once to the creditor matriarchy and to the matricidal enlightenment.

7.4

Death Has Her Mother's Face

Paul Celan's "Todesfuge" (1945/1948) is the poem that the 2018 sabbath answers point by point. Its refrain makes death a German: *der Tod ist ein Meister aus Deutschland*. It sets the golden hair of Margarete, Goethe's Gretchen and the beloved of German humanism's greatest drama, against the ashen hair of Shulamith, the bride of the Song of Songs; and it turns the mother's milk into the black milk of daybreak, drunk at evening, noon and morning. The 2018 film's chamber is walled with braided hair conceived as the hair of victims: Shulamith's ashen hair made architecture. Its Death is a woman wearing a mother's face, who serves the Mother of Sighs and kills the German coven's usurpers. The film takes Death from the German master and returns it to the Mother, and imagines a mother whose milk is not black.

In his Meridian address of 1960, Celan wrote that poetry may mean an *Atemwende*, a turn of breath. The sabbath is an *Atemwende*: breath turned away from the usurpers, who lose theirs, toward the oppressed, who are released. Celan's visit to Heidegger at Todtnauberg in July 1967, and the poem that recorded his hope for a word to come from a thinker's heart, a word that did not come, belong to the same Freiburg constellation as the academy's façade. Luce Irigaray's *L'Oubli de l'air chez Martin Heidegger* (1983) diagnosed the silence: the philosopher of the house of Being had forgotten air, the element that the

mother gives with life and on which every speaking being depends. The thinker of Freiburg forgot breath and was silent before the poet of breath. The 2018 film remembers air, and makes the Mother its sovereign.

7.5

The Grand Inquisitress: A Critique of Suspirial Sovereignty

Suspirial sovereignty is open to four objections, and the film supplies the evidence for each.

The first concerns the benevolent tyrant. In *Deutschland im Herbst*, Fassbinder's mother wished for an authoritarian ruler who would be thoroughly good, kind and orderly. The 2018 film fulfils the wish: its Mother is good to the victims, kind to the witness and orderly in her house, which resumes its routine the next morning. Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor, the aged cardinal of Seville who has just burned heretics in an auto-da-fé, tells the returned Christ that human beings prefer peace, even death, to the freedom of choosing between good and evil, and that the Church, through miracle, mystery and authority, has relieved them of the burden of conscience by taking their sins upon itself (*The Brothers Karamazov*, 1880). Susie relieves Klemperer of the burden of conscience by verdict and of memory by touch. The Inquisition that the *Malleus* armed returns, at the end of the 2018 film, as mercy. Its sovereign is a Grand Inquisitress.

The second concerns the mercy death. In October 1939 Hitler signed, and backdated to 1 September, the authorisation that empowered physicians to grant a "mercy death" (*Gnadentod*) to patients judged incurable, and charged Philipp Bouhler, head of his chancellery, and his physician Karl Brandt with carrying it out. Under the programme known as Aktion T4, doctors selected psychiatric patients and disabled people, some seventy thousand of whom were murdered by August 1941, most of them in gas chambers disguised as showers at six killing centres in Germany and Austria; a separate programme had been killing disabled children since 1939. After the official halt in August 1941 the killing continued inside institutions through starvation and lethal medication, and T4 personnel, Christian Wirth and Franz Stangl among them, were transferred to Bełżec, Sobibór and Treblinka, where their methods were used to murder some 1.7 million Jews, most of them from occupied Poland, with transports from Theresienstadt among them. As Henry Friedlander showed in *The Origins of Nazi Genocide* (1995), the "mercy death" was the administrative and technical prelude to the gas chambers of the Holocaust. In Freiburg, on 18 November 1941, the pathologist Franz Büchner delivered a public lecture on "The Oath of Hippocrates," the only open protest by a German physician against the killings; the oath forbids the physician to give a deadly drug to anyone, even on request. The 2018 Mother's gift stands between the oath and the crime. It differs from the National Socialist programme in two respects: it answers a request, and the giver gains nothing from the deaths, whereas Markos fed on bodies. A third difference that the film seems to offer does not hold. The bodies that ask for death were not ruined by the old regime

alone. The matrons kept Patricia in the catacombs between life and death and cut Sara open at the start of the sabbath; but Olga's bones were broken by Susie's own dance, at a rehearsal Blanc directed, so that the Mother who grants Olga death is the one through whose movements she was destroyed. The requests are made under domination, by bodies that the coven and its future sovereign ruined, and the sovereign alone judges them. Jean Améry's *Hand an sich legen: Diskurs über den Freitod* (1976) marks the position the film leaves out. Améry, whom the Gestapo had tortured at Breendonk and who survived Auschwitz, defended voluntary death as an act belonging to the person alone, and refused physicians, psychiatry and society any authority to decide it; he ended his own life in Salzburg in October 1978. His position condemns the National Socialist programme, which decided for its victims, and it also judges the film: the request is the dying women's, but the decision is the sovereign's. Contemporary bioethics continues to dispute death on request, and this dissertation analyses the film's distinction without adjudicating that debate. Its point is narrower: in the film, mercy depends entirely on the goodness of the one who dispenses it.

The third concerns the erasure of the witness. Herman warned that forgetting is the perpetrator's first defence; Loraux showed that the divided city founded its peace on an amnesty that suppressed the mother's unforgetting grief. The Mother transfers memory from the human witness to a divine archive: she remembers Anke, and Klemperer forgets. What remains is memory without human bearers, initials on a dacha wall that no one reads. A society whose last witness has been relieved of his memory has completed its *Schlussstrich* by the hand of mercy.

The fourth concerns the violence itself. The bursting heads of the sabbath echo Ulrike Meinhof's description of isolation as the feeling that one's head is exploding: the sovereign's violence reproduces the effect of the conditions that the RAF prisoners and their lawyers denounced as isolation torture and that the Federal Republic defended as security measures. Kristeva's warning applies: a liberation more sacrificial than the order it overthrows. The film's last image confirms the drift. In a post-credits scene Susie stands alone and gazes, approvingly, at something outside the academy: the satisfied look of a sovereign surveying her world.

Suspirial sovereignty is nonetheless a real advance over what it replaces. Unlike the creditor matriarchy, it hears the sigh, releases rather than consumes, and reassigns guilt to the guilty; unlike the matricidal enlightenment, it does not purchase the daughter's freedom with the mother's death. But it remains sovereignty: a power that decides alone whom to kill, whom to release and what to remember, and whose mercy answers to no one. Its political form is the benevolent authoritarian; its theological form, the Grand Inquisitor. The film answers the sigh with a throne.

7.6

From Sovereignty to Conspiration

The difficulty lies not in the Mother's answer but in its form. The sigh calls for an answer; the question is who answers it and how. Benjamin's messianic power is, by his own account, weak, and it is given to every generation rather than to a sovereign: redemption is distributed. The constellation assembled in the preceding chapters contains the figures of an answer that does not become sovereignty. The women of the Salento who danced at Galatina, the thirty women who gathered before Sethe's house and raised a sound older than words, and the people of Baby Suggs's Clearing, who laughed, danced and wept in one another's presence without anyone taking another's form, all answer the sigh by breathing together. That is conspiration without possession. The Conclusion argues that it is the proper form of a humanism adequate to what the two *Suspiria*s reveal.

CONCLUSION

From Sovereignty to Conspiration

Toward a Humanism of the Sigh



CONSP

C.1

The Argument Restated

The two *Suspiria*s form a single inquiry conducted across forty-one years. The film that Dario Argento and Daria Nicolodi wrote in 1976 is a fable of enlightenment in which a daughter becomes a subject by finding, illuminating and killing a maternal sovereign who exists as breath. Its façade is the house Erasmus lived in, its ground the Upper Rhine of the *Malleus*, its locations the beer hall and parade ground of the National Socialist movement, its Mother's house founded in the year modernity acquired its apparatus for exposing the hidden, and its ending an auto-da-fé lit by the lightning of *Aufklärung*. The film that David Kajganich wrote and Luca Guadagnino directed reads that fable as the unconscious of its own year. Its Berlin of 1977 is a city in which a nation's reckoning with its mothers is unfinished; its coven is a creditor matriarchy that consumes the young to keep a dead past alive; its crypt holds the drowned; its dance is called *Volk*. Its daughter does not kill the Mother but becomes her, and the power she exercises, suspirial sovereignty, answers the sigh with three gifts and one violence. Chapter Seven showed the price: a benevolent authoritarianism whose mercy answers to no one, a Grand Inquisitress who relieves the witness of conscience and memory alike. The two films describe a dialectic whose third term neither occupies. Enlightenment kills the Mother; the Mother answers by enthroning herself. What remains to be thought is an answer to the sigh that is neither matricide nor sovereignty.

C.2

Four Figures of the Subject

The films present three figures of the subject, and the argument requires a fourth. The first is the upright subject: Pico's Adam, who gives himself his own form; the ballerina raised onto pointe; Suzy standing in the rain before the burning house. Adriana Cavarero's *Inclinazioni* (2013) has criticised the rectitude of this figure, the vertical self of the philosophical tradition that stands by itself and owes nothing, and has opposed to it the posture of inclination, exemplified by the mother who bends toward a child. The second is the possessed subject: the dancer of *Volk* who receives the image of her creator, Luther's will ridden by another, the borrowed body of Markos's economy. The third is the sovereign subject: the Mother who opens her own breast and commands Death, and decides for others whom to kill, whom to release and what they will remember.

The fourth figure is the subject of the humanism of the sigh: the breathing, inclined and indebted creature. It is breathing because its humanity lies first in the voice of pain that Aristotle assigned to animals, the *phōnē* beneath *logos*, in the air whose forgetting Irigaray diagnosed in the philosopher of Freiburg, in the turn of breath that Celan called poetry. It is inclined because it bends toward others rather than standing upright by itself. De Quincey's Lady of Sighs, whose head droops

toward the dust, was drawn in 1845 as an image of abjection; the humanism of the sigh reads the same posture as inclination toward the oppressed she visits. And it is indebted, though not to a creditor. It owes the mother the air she gave with life and owes the dead the air into which they sighed, but these debts are owed to no one who can collect them. They cannot be exacted from anyone's body, as Markos exacts hers, and they are carried in common, as Benjamin's secret agreement between the generations is carried by every generation together.

C.3

Six Theses on Conspiration

The political form of this humanism is conspiration, breathing together without anyone breathing through another. It can be stated in six theses.

I. **On hearing.** The first political act is to hear the sigh as a claim. The disbelieved testimony of women (Patricia, Anke, Dora, Cassandra) is the paradigm of the sigh unheard, and the founding scene of liberation in Exodus begins with a groaning that is heard. Before it is anything else, the humanism of the sigh is an epistemology of credence.

II. **On breath.** Conspiration excludes possession. Its criterion is Edith Stein's distinction between empathy and fusion: the other's breath is felt, and remains the other's. Its figures are Baby Suggs's Clearing, the women who gathered before Sethe's house, the dancers of Galatina and Dore Hoyer's *Affectos Humanos*; its counter-figure is *Volk*.

III. **On memory.** The witness must be relieved, but not by forgetting. The burden the Mother lifts from Klemperer by erasure must be lifted by sharing, so that memory is distributed among the living rather than delegated to a god, and the unforgetting grief that Loraux showed the city fearing becomes a civic practice. Christa Wolf's *Kindheitsmuster* (1976), in which a German woman returns with her daughter to the town of her Nazi childhood, opens with Faulkner's sentence that the past is not dead, not even past, and adds that we cut it off from ourselves and pretend to be strangers. Conspiration is the refusal to pretend.

IV. **On debt.** Guilt is to be assigned where Jaspers placed criminal and political guilt: on those who acted and those who consented. Metaphysical guilt, which Jaspers himself grounded in the solidarity that makes every human being co-responsible for every wrong, is to be turned back into that solidarity and carried in common, never collected from the bodies of the young. The jubilee is not a sovereign's gift but a rule that a community gives itself.

V. **On mercy.** Where suffering calls for mercy, mercy must answer to the one who suffers and to those who care for her, never to a power that decides alone. The film's distinction between the Mother's gift and the regime's "mercy death" holds only so long as the Mother is good, and a humanism of the sigh cannot rest on the goodness of sovereigns.

VI. **On natality.** Matrigenesis is to be generalised and dethroned. Everyone who begins something new is born again as the origin of that beginning, in Arendt's sense of natality, and every woman may hold authority in Muraro's sense without seizing power. The birth of the Mother is the model of a beginning, not of a reign. The humanism of the sigh lets each person become the mother of a beginning and makes no one the sovereign of the house.

C.4

The Spectator as Bearer of Memory

The 2018 film points beyond its own sovereign resolution, in its form rather than its plot. Its coda, set in the present day, shows the initials of Josef and Anke carved into the wall of the dacha, unnoticed by the people who now live there. The occupants do not read them and Klemperer can no longer read them, but the spectators do. The goddess took the witness's memory; the film gives it to its audience. The last transfer of memory in *Suspiria* is not to a divine archive but to the people in the cinema. Cinema, born in 1895, the year the academy was founded, served in 1977 as an apparatus of exposure, the instrument that killed the Mother by making her visible. In 2018 it becomes an apparatus of shared memory, and a cinema audience is a conspiration in the literal sense: strangers breathing together in the dark before the images of the dead. What the plot entrusts to a goddess, the form hands to the living.

The casting of Jessica Harper states the same proposition in a single face. The heroine of the 1977 film, the girl who rose by killing the Mother, returns in 2018 as Anke, the woman who vanished into Theresienstadt and whose fate only the Mother knows. The emancipated subject of the matricidal enlightenment and the victim whose memory the goddess guards are played by one woman. The humanism of the sigh begins from that identity: the one who rises may become the one who vanishes, and the one who vanished was once the one who rose.

C.5

Contributions, Limits and Further Research

This dissertation has made five contributions. It has read a remake as a palimpsest and a constellation, in which the later film is the historical unconscious of the earlier one. It has proposed five concepts: matrigenesis, the creditor matriarchy, suspirial sovereignty, conspiration and the humanism of the sigh. It has reconstructed a genealogy of the Three Mothers that joins De Quincey's Lady of Sighs to Marx's sigh of the oppressed creature, to Pauline pneumatology and to the Shekhinah. It has situated the 2018 film's dance in the history of *Ausdruckstanz* and read it as a choreography of breath. And it has submitted the 2018 film's resolution to a critique drawn from Benjamin and Dostoevsky.

Its limits are equally plain. The readings flagged as controlled overinterpretation make no claim about the filmmakers' intentions. Production details rest on published interviews and reportage. The other films of Argento's cycle, *Inferno* and *La terza madre*, appear only in passing, and the films' reception outside Europe and North America is not addressed. The 2018 film's invocation of Kālī would require a competence in South Asian religious traditions that this study does not claim.

Three lines of further research follow. The first is a study of the cycle's Roman film, *La terza madre*, as the Catholic theatre of the Mother of Tears, the counterpart to the German theatre of the Mother of Sighs. The second is a sound study of breath across Goblin's score and Thom Yorke's. The third is a feminine pneumatology. The Hebrew *ruach*, the breath or spirit that moves over the waters in Genesis, is usually grammatically feminine; early Syriac Christianity could speak of the Spirit as mother; and in a fragment of the lost Gospel of the Hebrews, preserved by Origen and Jerome, Jesus speaks of "my mother, the Holy Spirit," who took him by one of his hairs and carried him to Mount Tabor. A theology of the sigh would find there a maternal breath that carries the creature without possessing it.

C.6

Coda: Into the Winds

The epigraph from Virgil records the last moment of Dido's agony: Iris, sent by Juno, cuts a lock of her hair, and her life withdraws into the winds. The image gathers the elements this dissertation has followed: a mother-goddess's pity, a messenger named for the iris, a single hair, a breath released into the common air. Benjamin asked whether a breath of the air that surrounded those who came before does not brush against us. Both *Suspiria*s answer that it does. The 1977 film hears that breath as a snore in the dark and silences it; the 2018 film hears it as a sigh and enthrones the one who answers it. The humanism of the sigh begins from a fact that both films, each in its own way, make visible: the air we breathe is the air into which the dead have sighed. To breathe it together, without taking

anyone's breath and without surrendering our own to a throne, is the least that the living owe them, and the most.

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KEYWORDS

Suspiria • *Dario Argento* • *Daria Nicolodi* • *Luca Guadagnino* • *David Kajganich* • *Thomas De Quincey* • Suspiria de Profundis • *Three Mothers* • *Mater Suspiriorum* • *Mater Dolorosa* • *matricide* • *matrigenesis* • *creditor matriarchy* • *suspirial sovereignty* • *conspiration* • *humanism of the sigh* • *remake as palimpsest* • *constellation* (*Benjamin, Adorno*) • *controlled overinterpretation* • *Renaissance humanism* • *Pico della Mirandola* • *Erasmus* • Malleus Maleficarum • *witch-hunt* • *Female Gothic* • *fairy tale and the split mother* • *dialectic of enlightenment* • *chromatic metaphysics* • *Goethe's theory of colour* • *acousmêtre* • *semiotic chora* • *feminist film theory* • *monstrous-feminine* • *abjection* • *Final Girl* • Ausdruckstanz • *Mary Wigman* • *Pina Bausch* • *mass ornament* • *fascinating fascism* • *hysteria* • *possession* • *tarantism* • *crisis of presence* • *German Autumn* • *Red Army Faction* • Vergangenheitsbewältigung • Mütterfilm • Mittäterschaft • *Holocaust memory* • *transgenerational trauma* • *crypt and phantom* • Schuld (*guilt and debt*) • *metaphysical guilt* • *survivor guilt* • *testimony* • *witness* • *memory and forgetting* • *amnesty* • *forgiveness* • *mythic and divine violence* • *sovereignty* • *biopolitics* • *necropolitics* • *natality* • *inclination* • *maternal authority* • affidamento • *goddess feminism* • *cyborg* • *difference feminism* • *breath* • pneuma • phōnē *and* logos • *voice* • *Irigaray* • *Kristeva* • *Cavarero* • *Muraro* • *Arendt* • *Benjamin* • *Celan* • Todesfuge

